

CASE STUDY

ANATOMY OF A \$10M ONLINE EDUCATION BUSINESS



OLLY RICHARDS

“But you always seem to know the answers,” said Tiny Dragon.

Big Panda grinned.

“Well, I have made a lot more mistakes than you.”

- The Journey, James Norbury

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Introduction

Welcome, friend.

What you are about to read is a case study into my online education business, StoryLearning.com, which I founded in a dusty café in the Middle East in 2013.

Today, I run the business from my home in the English countryside, surrounded by cows, dodgy internet and some of the most gorgeous beaches in the country.



At the start, I had no idea what I was doing. But someone had told me that I could write a blog about my hobby, learning foreign languages.

And so I did.

Here's what StoryLearning eventually turned into:

- A \$10m education business
- Profit margins of 50%+
- Fully bootstrapped with zero investment or debt
- An audience in the millions (monthly)
- And with books on the shelves of every major bookstore worldwide

My workload?

About six days a month.

This case study is a deep-dive into how StoryLearning works. If you are an educator, course creator, or otherwise sell your expertise online, I wrote this case study for you, in the hope that you can draw inspiration from what I've built.

Best case, you'll be able to commandeer some of the ideas in here to help you build a more profitable education business, that is based on one important principle:

A business should create an abundance of time and resources for you to live life the exact way you want *right now*... not in the future.

There is a time and a place for hustle, to be sure.

But there's also a time for the hustle to end.

Where you can allow the business to exist in harmony and alignment with everything else that matters to you in life.

For me, that includes a bunch of things:

- Collecting my daughter from school every day
- Morning walks on the beach... then brunch... why not?
- Flying (I'm studying for my PPL)
- Meeting my trainer twice a week (for an ass-kicking)
- Long weekends away
- ... or just taking the day off for the hell of it

A typical week for me includes most of these things. (More of that in the final chapter.)

And this is all possible because I've deliberately designed a business that is optimised for lifestyle and profitability *in equal measure*.

Hustle can be the enemy of this.

"More" is not always good.

This is something that no-one teaches you.

I'm not writing this for high-growth, venture-funded startups. I'm writing this for independent entrepreneurs who want to build a highly profitable business that gives you the time, money and resources to live a full life now, not in some hypothetical future sale event where you sail off into the sunset.

Now, your business won't look exactly like mine.

And it shouldn't.

In fact, I have a set of unfair advantages that I've built up over the years that means it's probably impossible for you to design a business exactly like mine. And you wouldn't want to either - I've carefully built StoryLearning to fit my personal preferences, and actively shunned "big opportunities" that I simply didn't think I'd enjoy.

So your business won't be the same as mine, but if you want to grow your business in a way that gives you **more time and cashflow**, then I dare say you'll have mindset and strategy blocks that are similar to what I've encountered.

As a clever chap once said:

"There are no such things as business problems, only mindset problems."

And by God, I've found this to be true. So, on the assumption that whatever lies between you and the business you want to build is simply a set of mindset adjustments, you're going to find a lot to inspire you in this case study.

Here are some of the things you'll learn:

- How we sell in ecosystems rather than funnels (and why it works)
- Our "world building" approach to maximising customer value
- How we have diversified... and why you shouldn't
- What I've learnt about growing an audience of millions
- Our philosophy to reinvesting the money we earn
- The "8-figure org chart" that runs StoryLearning without me
- Some thoughts on the personal side - lifestyle & personal wealth

Why should you pay attention to any of this?

Perhaps you shouldn't. After all, this is just one person's experience.

I don't know about you, but I've never found it easy to find good case studies of real online businesses.

But the way I see it...

If 118 straight pages of opening the kimono doesn't convince you to pay attention...

Then it most likely isn't right for you anyway.

So take it or leave it. If I do my job properly, you'll take it.

Everything you'll read here has come about from almost 10 years of direct, real-world experience and experimentation.

Behind the scenes, I have battled with anxiety, uncertainty, fear, and simply not knowing what the hell I'm doing. And hopefully that's what will make this valuable - I know in my bones that building a successful business is only 20% the "stuff you do".

The other 80% is battling with yourself.

That's why I like to think in terms of principles, rather than tactics. Principles serve you better. (Especially when you've learnt them first-hand.)

I've also enjoyed mentoring dozens of entrepreneurs, and seen the exact same fear, confusion and overwhelm in their eyes. If I can spare you even some of these battles, this will be worthwhile.

It's not that I know more than you. I've just made more mistakes.

So, I hope you enjoy this case study and the email newsletter that I'll send along with it, which I commit to making just as valuable.

At the very least, I hope it will inspire you.

At the most, I hope you'll take these ideas and do something with them.

I'm sitting here, as I'm editing this manuscript at 09:30 on a Friday morning:



If I see you strolling down the beach over there sometime soon, sipping a coffee and enjoying the sun on a Friday morning, I'll know you're on the right track.

A Word On Inspiration

Picasso famously said: *“Good artists borrow, great artists steal.”*

And like everyone else, I steal.

In this case study, you’re going to hear a lot from me about the concepts, strategies and philosophies I have used to grow StoryLearning.com into a multi-million dollar business.

But many of these ideas I have learnt from other people.

As years go by, ideas evolve as they come into contact with reality, and it can be difficult to keep track of who they came from.

In this spirit, I want to acknowledge some key people who have shaped how I think about business. You will find traces of all these people in everything I do.

1. Ben Settle - taught me to find my voice
2. Scott Oldford - taught me to see my potential
3. André Chaperon - taught me to write emails
4. Dan Kennedy - taught me to think
5. Russell Brunson - taught me to sell
6. Michael Singer - taught me to cope with it all

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1. Crafting The Magic

In this chapter, I'll describe how I have grown StoryLearning by deliberately carving out a profitable niche position in our industry. Read this chapter if you want to cultivate a dedicated fanbase that buys frequently and spends liberally.

Let's begin with the stuff that nobody wants to talk about.

Every marketing course worth its salt teaches this, and yet everyone skips it... eager to skip to the sexy stuff.

I'm talking about: *USP, positioning, niche.*

(Take your pick of the buzzwords.)

But it's so much more than this...

What we're talking about here is the very DNA of your business - the thing that makes it unique, the magic ingredient that makes it irresistible to customers, turns customers into super fans, makes them share it with their friends, makes it impossible for them *not* to buy your latest product, creates viral properties among new businesses, unbeatable traction that leaves competitors flailing in the dust, scratching their heads wondering what on earth you're doing that they simply cannot emulate.

Your Business DNA

Let me describe the DNA of StoryLearning.

StoryLearning is a language learning business. We teach foreign languages through digital courses, books and coaching.

StoryLearning has a very simple proposition – *Learn a language through stories.*

A phrase I often use to communicate the ethos of this is: "Learn a language through stories, not rules."

I won't go into the whole backstory here, although you can [read about it here](#) on the website if you like. (Reading about this origin story is a mini lesson in itself, by the way – you'd be amazed how often I meet people who have read my origin story and never forgot it!)

Here's what's important...

The language learning space is a very competitive niche, full of well-known incumbents like Rosetta Stone and Duolingo. Many of these are huge, venture-backed companies.

So, how do we compete?

With our niche, that's how.

Every single thing we do inside our business uses stories. Whether it's the emails we write, the courses we sell, our books in the shops... you won't find anything we do that does not have a story at the centre.

Even our [YouTube videos](#) focus on telling stories.

To put it another way, “stories” is the organising principle of the business.

This has a number of effects...

- We stand out in a very crowded niche, with a very clear offering unlike anything else out there.
- This turns off a lot of people. But this is important, because for the right kind of person, it makes our brand utterly irresistible. For someone who likes the idea of stories, it's a no-brainer to try StoryLearning.
- This uniqueness allows us to charge higher prices...higher than virtually anyone else. Thanks to higher pricing, we get better customers – because higher paying customers are always better customers.
- These customers (assuming they like our courses), become super-fans, because we give them something they cannot get elsewhere
- As a result, customers end up purchasing more, often a lot more... In many cases literally everything we have ever sold.

You can only reach this kind of “heat” in a customer when you create an irrational passion. We do this by occupying a very specific space in the language learning world.

What we try to do, in fact, is to completely own the word “stories” within language learning.

Obviously we have competitors who try to copy what we do, but you'd be hard-pressed to find anyone familiar with the language space who doesn't think of StoryLearning when you mention learning a language with stories.

It's this dogged focus on a tight, narrow positioning that allows us to go all-in and to create the impact we do.

Now, it goes without saying that you have to be able to back all this up with a world-class product.

But as you will see later, for most educators, the *teaching* part is not the hard bit. Teaching is what comes naturally to us. It's the *marketing* that we have to work at.

This was definitely the case for me.

In fact, when I first started, back in 2013, the name of the blog was *I Will Teach You A Language*, a name I shamelessly stole from Ramit Sethi's famous [‘I will teach you to be rich’](#) business.

That's how original I was.

I've always been terrible at names.

It was only many years into the business, after we'd started to focus on stories, that I did a complete pivot and rebrand to *StoryLearning*.

(That was a scary moment. Imagine 301-redirecting your 500k-hits-a-month website to a new domain. I did that. And definitely lost a few nights' sleep.)

Creating A System

By rebranding from *I Will Teach You A Language* to *StoryLearning*, the key thing I achieved was to remove the focus from me and towards a system...

- **Before:** Learn a language with Olly (personal brand)
- **After:** Learn a language through stories (system)

...and this was a critical turning point for the business



Graphic showing the StoryLearning® method - our “system”

Having an identifiable system or methodology for the business helps a number of things:

1) Sales

Most people buy from emotion - they see something and just have to have it! But what happens next is that their logical brain goes through and performs a sense check – “am I making a stupid decision here?” A system or methodology speaks to the logical brain. When the logical brain can identify a system behind the product, it is satisfied, and allows the emotional brain to go ahead with the purchase.

So we started selling more.

2) Scale

Having a system or methodology means it doesn't have to be you teaching it anymore. Why? Because if it's the system you're selling, it's the system people are buying to get their results. The person delivering it matters less.

When I made my first courses, I was designing and teaching everything myself.

But after we defined the StoryLearning methodology, we were then able to bring in other expert tutors to teach the method.

I started positioning myself less as the ‘teacher’ and more as the ‘celebrity endorser’.

This bought me something more valuable than anything I own in this world - the ability to step away.

In other words...

Carefully crafting our niche positioning and defining our teaching methodology exploded our sales and dramatically freed up my time.

A lot of businesses get stuck at around \$500,000 in sales because the business is too reliant on their presence and involvement. Planning how the business can run without you is a vital step for growth.

But I know it ain't easy.

I remember when I first started taking business courses, everyone would talk about the importance of niche. But I didn't know what I wanted my niche to be. I remember tearing my hair out trying to find my niche. It took me years before landing on 'stories' as a concept, and that came about through endless experiments and restless searching.

I'm constantly amazed by people I meet who resist this concept and insist their business can be all things to all people. Big mistake. Figure this out, and insane traction is waiting for you on the other side.

So, if you've struggled to land on a unique and clearly-defined niche that you can summarise in one sentence, know that it's not easy.

But also know that you simply have to do it.

You have to craft the magic.

And things are going to get reeeeeal fun once you do :)

Summary

The success of the StoryLearning brand is down to very deliberate niche positioning within the language learning space. Having a tight niche makes it easier to sell, charge higher prices, and gain better customers.

Defining a teaching system or methodology has freed up my time by allowing expert tutors to fulfil on product instead of me, thereby rapidly expanding the business and reducing my time commitment

(Quick reminder – the paperback and kindle versions of this case study are available if you prefer to read that way. [Click here for that.](#))

2. The Product Ecosystem

In this chapter I'll describe our “ecosystem” of offers at StoryLearning – how it works and why we do it. Read this chapter if you want to earn more from your customers and sell in a more natural way.

Here is the concept I followed to build our products at StoryLearning:

World Building

To understand what world building is, think: Star Wars, Lord of the Rings, or the Marvel universe. The characters, the worlds, the storylines, the sub-plots. You can dip a toe in. Or you can spend a lifetime in starry-eyed fandom, losing yourself in the universe, buying the merchandise, joining the fan clubs... you get the idea.

Writers and creatives have been doing this since the dawn of time. But world building as applied to business is a concept I learnt from [Ben Settle](#). Ben's business is a masterclass in combining...

- A hell-a-strong, infectious brand identity, with
- A deep rabbit-hole of media and products

...that allow you to become as obsessed with the world of Ben as you would with the universe of Marvel.

As soon as I discovered what Ben had built, I knew instantly that I had the exact same opportunity with StoryLearning. It just hadn't clicked in my mind yet:

- An obsessive focus on stories for learning a language
- A world of story-based media and products to lose yourself in

With StoryLearning, as you read about in the first chapter, I crafted a brand that revolves around stories. Everything we do uses stories. And, by taking such a strong position, attracts superfans who love what we do.

From a sales perspective, this has really important implications. If you're a fan of a particular thing, you don't need to be sold to. You simply want to buy more and indulge in your fandom.

You take pleasure from consuming more.

When you need a fix, you have somewhere to go. If you want to indulge in a passion purchase, or buy in bulk, you can. And you're comfortable doing this because, as a fan, you know exactly what you're going to get.

With a world building approach, you can completely own an entire corner of the market. It's more than that, really. What you're actually doing is creating a brand new market, and making your competitors irrelevant in the process.

So, that's what I did with StoryLearning.

I built an entire moat around us by creating a world of products that reinforce the concept of stories:

- books of stories
- products based on stories
- YouTube videos telling stories about languages
- daily "soap opera" podcasts that tell a long-form story over 6 months

In a moment, I'll show you the precise offer structure within StoryLearning. But it's vital to understand this concept first, because what we do above all else is...

We create a world for our fans, in which they can indulge, learn, and purchase to their hearts' content.

If anyone tried to copy what we do, they would have a hard time, because even though they could copy the offers and the pricing, and even the products themselves, what they would lack is the DNA of the StoryLearning brand, and the excitement of the StoryLearning world once you are on the inside.

For example, we have characters in our stories who pop up around different products – someone you read about in one book might make an appearance in another. Or maybe in a podcast. The storyline in volume one of a book will continue into volume two, and so on.

So, it's really a rich world which, frankly, we haven't exploited even to 10% of what we could. But we are certainly working on it.

Selling Within An Ecosystem

In case you're wondering how we sell all this stuff...

On a really simple level, we simply make passing references to the various products in the StoryLearning universe, all the time.

- “You might remember this character from volume one of X”
- “And if you struggle with this particular grammar, we cover it in Y”
- “Oh, and in case you’re wondering, season 5 of the Z is coming out next week!”

What this does is simply leave breadcrumbs lying around for people who are interested to click through and buy. Or not. Maybe just check them out. And then buy later.

Or never.

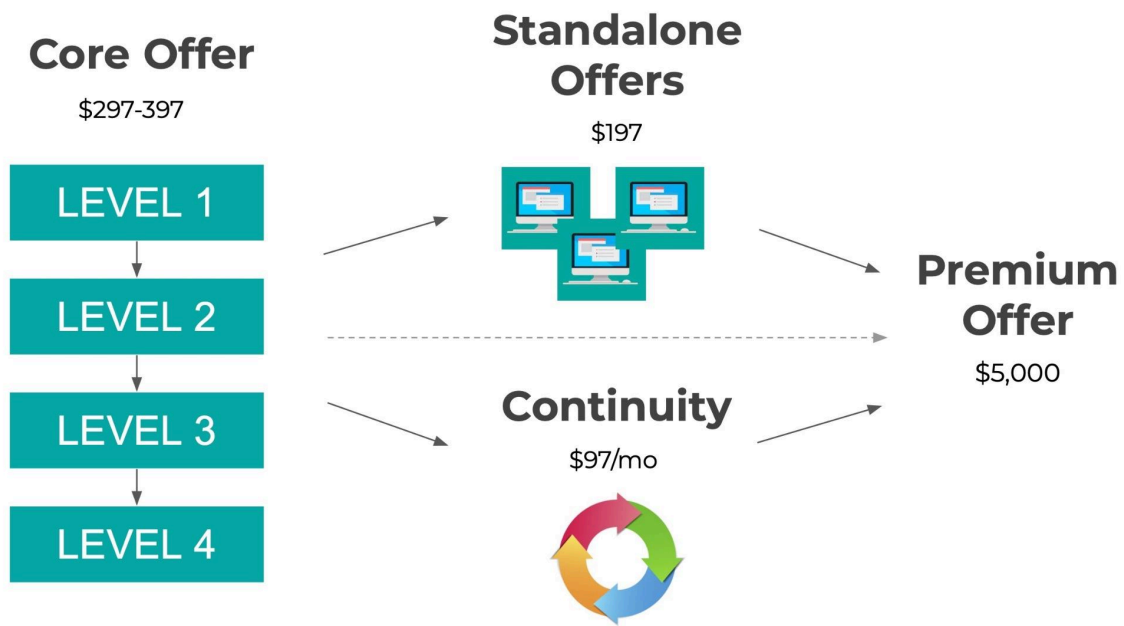
Doesn’t really matter.

Either way, this is a very passive approach that makes it so that, as your audience grows, you end up with sales flying at you left right and centre, and you don't even know where they're coming from.

It's a great problem to have, and a very natural by-product of world building over time. (*Time* is something we will cover in chapter 9.)

Having a wide ecosystem of products also creates the option for you to exploit the power of bundling, thereby raising your average customer value by many orders of magnitude. (Again something we will look at later.)

But, before we wade any deeper into the swamp, here is the conceptual structure of our product catalogue:



Want to know more?

Oh, go on then...

The Core Offer

At the front end of StoryLearning, we sell one thing, and one thing only – our Core Offer.

These are our flagship language courses – [Spanish Uncovered](#), [French Uncovered](#), etc. (We have this Core Offer in over 15 languages. Yes, we've been working hard.)

If you want to learn a new language, this is your first port of call.

Each of these courses comes in 4-6 levels, and this is very deliberate because it creates a pathway for people to follow.

Once you finish level one, if you like it, the obvious thing to do is to take level two, then three, then four.

From a financial perspective, this offer is the lifeblood of the business. It's what brings in the cash on a daily basis and gives you a business in the first place.

Structuring our programmes in this way also creates a very natural model for upsells. When someone enrolls in level one of a course, you can probably guess the one-time offer we make after checkout.

(And if you didn't get it... You will by the end of this case study.)

If you were to opt in to our email newsletter, you would be taken through an email funnel which is designed to sell you that same programme – The Core Offer.

Now, before you say “Well that sounds obvious!”, what’s important about this structure is what we do not sell.

For example, note that on our [website](#), you cannot buy the other offers. You won’t see them. You may not even know they exist... *even though* we make most of our money selling offers other than the Core Offer.

Our big revenue-generating products are not on display in the shop window. The reasons for this are threefold:

1. We want to have a Core Offer on display that represents the essence of what we offer to new visitors. (Other offers are primarily designed to be sold to existing customers - people who already understand StoryLearning and don’t need any convincing.)
2. We want to avoid the paradox of choice, where, faced with multiple things to buy, people end up buying nothing
3. The front-end is where we will do most of our testing and CRO, so it’s smart to optimise for operational simplicity. If we only sell one thing, it makes it a helluva lot easier to test.

Of the three reasons, number one is the philosophically most important one.

I see tonnes of education businesses who plaster multiple offers all over their website, presumably in the hope that someone will buy something, but all this says to me is a lack of conviction in who they are, who they help and what they offer.

What we’re trying to do at StoryLearning is construct a world *so strong*, and occupy a position in the language niche *so clear*, that anyone who so much as attempts to cross the moat and scale the ramparts will be immediately repelled with a barrage of crossbows, buckets of burning oil, and falling rocks.

We are going for depth of concept above all else.

I want a new visitor to come to the website and have really only one choice. Of course that means that the choice you give them has to be a damn good one, but that is the art of business, I suppose!

This is worth a quick detour...

It's quite common for me to meet business owners who don't have a strong front-end product that really snugly matches what their audience most wants. This is often called 'product-market fit', although I think it might be better rephrased as 'product-audience fit'. But, yeah, I know it doesn't sound so good.

People in this situation, if they have a large audience, can actually make quite a bit of money. But relatively few people buy directly from their website, or from their initial email funnels.

They're able to sell because they leverage their relationship with their audience. But the real test of a product is whether people who have *just discovered you* will buy. If that isn't happening, it's because the basic value proposition is just not strong enough.

And that's a real concern, because it will make it virtually impossible to scale beyond the limits of your existing fanbase.

If you find yourself in this situation, I suggest making it the number one thing you try to solve, because nothing else will work properly without it.

Conversely, once you get this right, and people start buying on-sight, everything will just take off like a rocket ship.

Anyway...

This is why the Core Offer matters.

The Standalone Offer

Lying in wait behind the core offer, we have three other types of offers.

It's essential to understand how these other offers work, because we make more money from these than from the core offer.

Conceptually, the important thing to understand is this – once we acquire a new customer (in this case, by selling the Core Offer), the way our business makes real

money is by offering more to those existing customers. This is direct response marketing 101, and it always amazes me how many people don't understand this, or else understand but don't implement it.

If you make less money on the backend than on the frontend, your business is dangerously under-optimised.

And so it's really important that you construct your offers in such a way that allow you to:

1. Gain a new customer with a strong Core Offer
2. Maximise the value of that customer with backend offers

It took us many years of product building, to get enough stuff in place to sell in the first place. In large part, this is because we work with over 10 languages, so what we really have is 10 separate businesses within one - and we need that entire product ecosystem for all 10 languages.

But, we are now in a place where we have all that product built now, and in the correct order, and we are profiting handsomely from it.

So first off, we have our Standalone Offers.

You can think of these as smaller, separate products that address one narrow problem within the overall niche.

For example, whereas our Core Offer is the straightforward "learn a new language" offer, a Standalone Product would be a deep-dive into, say, listening skills, grammar, memory, or language learning techniques. These compliment the Core Offer well, and simply give people the opportunity to go deeper on an area of interest.

Fun fact... these Standalone Offers were actually some of the first that we developed, but this was long before I had properly understood how a product ecosystem works. We ended up losing quite a bit of time in moving things around later, having to rewrite email funnels and offer sequences etc. I sure wish I'd had a clear view of this model when I first started building courses.

So, if these products are only sold on the backend, how do we go about selling them?

The way that we sell Standalone Offers is twofold:

1. Regular promotions to our email list
2. As upsells

If we tried to sell these on the front-end, by having them available on the website, they would do okay. But the fact that we instead only offer them to existing customers, who we have an established relationship with, means they are much easier to sell because people already know what they're going to get, and trust the quality of what we offer.

From a business model perspective, these are profit maximisers. Every time we run a promotion to sell these, we make \$10,000s, which dramatically increases the average value of a customer. When done well, over time, it might be the difference between an ACV of \$300 or \$1000.

The other benefit of having these products is that we can use them creatively as bonuses and premiums of different kinds. For example, let's say we wanted to run a New Year promotion for our Core Offer, we might bundle it up with a free Standalone Offer. It creates a legitimate way of adding value *without discounting*, which is something I have strong feelings about. (I'll cover it later if we have time.)

The Continuity Offer

Next up we have continuity.

I have a love-hate relationship with continuity, having tried it in so many forms over the years. This is largely a problem specific to the language learning niche though - what tends to happen with language learners is that they get all excited about learning a new language, and then a couple of months later realise that it's actually damn hard work, and take a break, get bored, or give up altogether... and cancel their subscriptions along with it.

Language learning isn't a straight line of progress. It's an ongoing mindset battle.

Of course you can mitigate this to some degree within your products, but it's a battle I'd rather not fight.

For this reason, I've always found that continuity was challenging because people will inevitably cancel after an average of 3 to 6 months while you have to keep offering and creating something new each month for the people who do stay.

Average customer values are lower than you think, and it's a massive psychological drain that can prevent you from focusing on scaling the rest of the business.

Indeed, StoryLearning took a giant leap forward once we cancelled our membership model back in 2017-18.

Now, don't be put off by this, because in other niches continuity is completely fine, and even preferable.

And even if you are in the language niche, you can definitely make continuity work, for example if you're willing to charge less, include some kind of live tutoring offering (which cuts your margins like there's no tomorrow), or are simply the kind of person who likes to serve a group of people day in day out.

Because of all this, the way we do the Continuity Offer in StoryLearning is not strict continuity – it's a hybrid model.

What we do is offer monthly 30-day challenges.

For each language we do this in, we have a 30-day challenge for each month of the year. And if you're doing the sums, yes, this is a lot of products!

This is not strict continuity, because we sell each challenge separately – there's no monthly re-bill. However, it functions in pretty much the same way, because most people take multiple challenges - sometimes all 12 of them. Sometimes, that buying cycle can be stretched out over a couple of years, but that's fine by me, because customers coming back for more is the lifeblood of the business.

Also, by making these single purchases, rather than a recurring payment, we can charge much more.

Here's why...

Psychologically, for a customer, \$100 per challenge (with the option of skipping whenever they want) is a lot more palatable than committing to a \$100/mth continuity.

That's tough for any niche.

However, we can get away with charging \$100 for each 30-day challenge because of our deep understanding of what customers need, the trust that's already been built (they are existing customers, remember), and, of course, the magnetic positioning of the StoryLearning brand that I discussed at the beginning of this case study.

So, when all's said and done, customers do end up paying month-in month-out, because, fundamentally, they want what we're offering

From an operational perspective, this is also far easier to manage than an ongoing membership, because we've already built all the challenges that run over the course of the year, and simply repeat the 12 challenges every year.

A couple of further points:

- Yes, there's a maximum of 12 months that people can sign up for, so the continuity isn't endless. However, any membership that retains a customer for 12 months is doing extremely well, so I'll take it.
- In case you're wondering – yes, we also sell bundles of these 12 challenges, which creates large amounts of upfront revenue.
- I have zero time involvement in any of the challenges. The materials are built up-front, and the live and community components are delivered by tutors.

The combination of high prices for monthly challenges, together with the up-front revenue that comes from bundles, creates a hybrid-continuity model that I would guess is 5-10x more profitable than anything similar in our niche.

From a business model perspective, think about the Continuity Offer as a way to enable your customers to continue spending with you over time. This creates a layer of recurring revenue in the business that brings real stability. As you scale, this predictable revenue allows you to grow your team with stability and predictability.

The High-Ticket Offer

Lastly we have the High-Ticket Offer.

High-ticket is an ugly phrase, but at least it does what it says on the tin. Many successful businesses are built entirely on their high-ticket offers, and is another kind of offer that I've had a real love-hate relationship with over the years, again mostly due to the peculiarities of the language learning space.

(If you're curious, "high-ticket" usually involves selling either "more advanced information" or "speed of implementation". However, neither of these things count in language learning, because it's much more about the hard work and dedication of the individual. For this reason it is difficult to sell "more information", and "speed" simply doesn't work unless you can get them to study harder – AKA the one thing most people don't want to do!)

StoryLearning's High-Ticket Offer is a teaching certification programme in which we train people to teach languages. The certification is a lot more high-touch, involves more staff, and we treat it conceptually as its own business. (It even has its own [website](#).)

You can see that it's not directly related to language learning - the High-Ticket Offer is not about helping people learn their new language faster. Instead, it is a "career change" offer, allowing students to train as a language teacher and build their own language teaching business, which of course is something we are also experts in, so it works nicely.

I would say that, in an ideal world, I'd like the High-Ticket Offer to be teaching the same thing as the rest of the business (in our case, learning a language), as it would be a lot easier to sell that way. But I saw the certification model as a much better long-term opportunity, because it's in line with global changes in society and education.

We'll come back to this way of thinking in chapter 9 on Diversification.

From a business model perspective, the function of the High-Ticket Offer is to offer the maximum amount of value you can, and charge accordingly. Our Core Offers sell for \$297-397, but the certification costs \$5,000. Doesn't take a genius to see what this does to average customer value.

Now, let me show you something that best demonstrates why having this combination of offers is important. Below you will see the chart of our average customer value over a six-year period from 2015-2021:



Up until 2018 the spend per customer is largely flat. Around 2017-18, we started in earnest to build out the product ecosystem you saw in this chapter. We completed it in 2020-21.

Can you see how average customer spend went up 3-4x?

(Note, this is not “number of new customers” – that is a different graph. This is simply how much one customer, on average, spends.)

Think for a moment, if your customers spent 4x what they do now, what would that mean for your business?

And that, my friend, is why a product ecosystem, well-conceived, and properly built-out, is so important.

You can think of this part of the ecosystem as a “growth fund” - it’s how you create excess cash flow which you can either take as dividends, or put back into funding growth elsewhere in the business.

Now, if you are looking at all of this and thinking... “How on Earth do you sell all of these things together?”... well, that will come later, because we have a very fixed structure that we have built out over years of experimentation.

Summary

Our products at StoryLearning fall into four strategic categories:

- **Core Offer** - Our flagship product, which is the single offer we make to all new prospects. Available evergreen.
- **Standalone Offer** - Solo, one-off products which are sold as promotions or upsells. Allow us to maximise customer lifetime value
- **Continuity Offer** - A way for existing customers to pay us every month. Allows us to build team in a safe and predictable way
- **High-Ticket Offer** - The maximum level of value we offer, usually to a small segment of customers. Produces large cash dividends to fund the future of the business.

3. How We Do Marketing

In this chapter, I'm going to tackle the thorny issue of marketing. Everyone has their own take on marketing, and this is mine. Read this chapter if you want to develop a more coherent, profitable approach towards marketing, from emails to content to sales pages.

Here's what I have discovered about marketing over 10 years of growing StoryLearning:

Most marketing education is a colossal oversimplification.

Mainstream marketing education leads us to use terms like *leads*, *top of funnel* or *sales* as if they were completely separate concepts.

These concepts are probably useful for beginners to begin to grasp the concept of selling, but what I have come to discover about high-functioning education businesses is that...

Marketing, sales, brand and product are ultimately all the same thing.

All these concepts that are taught as separate pieces of the puzzle, are actually all part of the same pie. Like twins joined at birth, they simply cannot be separated.

When you follow a world building approach like I described in chapter 2, marketing is literally baked into everything you do.

From the emails you send, to the blog posts you write, to the experience inside your products. When you are carving a niche for yourself in the world, you are creating a living creature from scratch, with its own unique DNA which can be felt and experienced in absolutely everything you do.

The problem with paying attention to traditional marketing education, is that you start to think of different pieces of the sales and marketing process as, well, separate.

People spend \$1,000s on courses learning to write the perfect sales page... as if "conversion" is something that only happens on the sales page. Horse s**t. If you've built your brand properly, then a customer should be 99% sold -- i.e. they know they want to buy from you -- before they get anywhere near the sales page.

And this begins right back in the first moment someone discovers your work -- a blog post, video, or tweet -- and continues through every single touch point someone has with you right up until the point of buying... and beyond.

This is world building in all its glory.

The sales page...

The email sequence...

The phone call...

Yes, it's useful to think about what you do in each of these stages, but I think there is something much deeper and more meaningful to discover about marketing, and it comes down to everything we're talking about in this case study -- your niche and positioning as a business, the world you are building.

Anyway, stepping off my soap box for just a second, I think what I'll do here is simply describe how I think about marketing for StoryLearning, and you're either going to love it or hate it.

But at least this way I stand a chance of offering you a few epiphany moments. And that itself is an important marketing lesson -- far better to offer one specific idea, and say it clearly, than it is to speak in general terms and to try and cover everything.

So here goes...

[-- clears throat --]

Most marketing that is taught online is based on direct response marketing.

Direct response marketing is the idea that you can send messages (adverts) to cold prospects (people who have never heard of you), and with the perfectly crafted sales message (copy), persuade a certain percentage of people to buy today (conversion).

If you can do this well, with the right product, in the right market, at the right time, there is immense profit to be uncovered.

To get there, you'll do things like:

- split test your sales pages
- hire a sales team
- follow up with prospects until they either buy or unsubscribe

- add an elaborate series of upsells and downsells
- inject NLP into your copy
- add “fake closes” to your launches

And a whole myriad of things that are designed to get someone to buy *right now* and maximise the amount they’ll spend -- by hook or by crook.

But that’s not the game I’m in.

The reason I can say this with high conviction is because I did, in fact, spend years learning and doing this stuff. Unfortunately, I’m also rather good at it. (I learnt from the best.)

And I’m not saying *not* to do these things. At StoryLearning, we do, in fact, do many of these things. But it’s more of a philosophical approach to business, an approach that dictates how you prefer to use your time, energy and focus.

To use a Jason Fried-ism, I’m [against maximisation](#).

“I’m not interested in squeezing something so tight that I get every last drop. I don’t want, need, or care about every last drop. Those last drops usually don’t taste as good anyway. My thirst is usually well quenched far before that final drop.”

I’m in the game of building a long-term, sustainable, audience-first education brand. Which is the business that most educators want to be in.

With a niche education business, I think you have a different set of opportunities.

The big opportunity you have on the table is your relationship with your audience.

Students tend to gravitate to people.

They want to learn from people, and once they become a disciple of a person or teacher, they will remain disciples for years, if not for life.

Once they are a fan of an educator, they really, really love to buy from them. (But being sold to will turn them off faster than Lady Gaga hatching out of an egg.)

Not only that, but when you operate in a niche or specialist field (as opposed to mass market), then by definition, it takes people time to understand what you do and appreciate the depth of your approach.

For example, with StoryLearning, we offer people the ability to learn a new language through stories. Now, as intriguing as this may sound, we still have a lot of explaining to do before someone is ready to pull the trigger, especially at our higher price points. *“So, how does it work exactly?”*

Not only that, we know full well that our methodology is not for everyone. Because of this, it’s actually against our interests to try and sell someone too hard, because the wrong person will simply not benefit from the product, will likely refund, and may generate negative word of mouth.

(The opposite of this, for example, may be a generic, \$37, *“Learn Spanish Fast!”* offer that you might see on an Instagram ad. This is a generic impulse purchase, needs little explanation, and is therefore more suitable to direct marketing.)

In other words, it seems to me that a direct marketing approach is antithetical to what we’re trying to do, because it relies so much on a transactional relationship.

I don’t want to be the aspirin to someone’s headache.

I want to be the organic veg someone pays through the nose for because they value their health.

More to the point...

I don’t want to spend my days trying to persuade every Tom, Dick and Harry to invest in something I’ve poured my heart into creating that they won’t appreciate anyway.

The reason I’m spending so long on this is because so many people I meet think about marketing in this way.

They’ve taken too many marketing courses, attended too many conference talks, hung out in too many Facebook groups.

And I get it -- when you’re growing a business and someone’s sliding into your DMs telling you they can make you more money... it is difficult to ignore it.

But having spent too many years disappearing down these rabbit holes, I feel like I’ve found a very happy medium with StoryLearning, where we treat marketing in a more pleasant way, and still make millions of dollars doing it.

My Marketing Logic

The logic goes...

- The single biggest asset we have in our business is our audience, and the relationship we have with them, because...
- If our audience gets value from what we do, they will continue to do business with us, which means...
- The more time goes by, the more valuable our audience becomes, so...
- The business priority is to build a relationship with every new person in our audience -- through teaching and entertainment -- free and paid

Now, if you think of marketing in these terms...

The only thing that can work against you is... being in a hurry!

The more of a hurry you are in, the more you will resort to marketing tricks and hacks, simply “maximising” the wrong thing.

On the other hand, when you’re not in a hurry, you will naturally do the thing that attracted people to you in the first place.

Naturally, this approach will be mocked and jeered at by startup junkies, crazed hustlers hungry for scale, or anyone who is just in it for cold, hard cash.

But it's important to remember what you want here.

Personally, I want to do something I love, with healthy profits and the absolute time freedom to live life the exact way I like it. I would not sacrifice any of those three pillars for any amount of cash.

Selling With Content

So, at StoryLearning, we lead with content.

Content is the way we attract people, and the way we sell. (Call it Content Marketing if you must.)

Here’s how I think about content:

1. I can't control when the customer will buy, so instead I focus on showing up, being relevant, and offering regular invitations to go deeper by joining a paid programme
2. When I'm the one showing up in their inbox and YouTube feed every day, I stay top-of-mind and relevant to them
3. Since I don't seek to control buyer behaviour, each and every piece of content I put out needs to be thought of as contributing to marketing and sales

Which begs the question...

How does content contribute to marketing and sales?

Basically, we try to ensure that anyone who spends any time engaging with our content regularly encounters the key parts of the StoryLearning value proposition.

To put it another way -- our “talking points” are everywhere.

We cover our talking points in a content framework, which looks like this:

StoryLearning Content Framework:

- What is this and how is it different?
- What do I get from you?
- Where did it come from? (Origin story)
- Who is this NOT for?
- Problem and solution
- How does it work?
- Why should I listen?
- Logical urgency
- Proof, testimonials, case studies

It would take me an entire book to explain all of these, but here's what's important:

What you see in this content framework is everything that a prospect needs to believe or understand in order to be ready to buy a StoryLearning course.

In all content that we create, we aim to cycle regularly through all messages in this content framework.

Sometimes these points may be dropped in as a throwaway comment - in the middle of a video, for example - but you can be sure it will be heard and registered if you have people's attention through quality content.

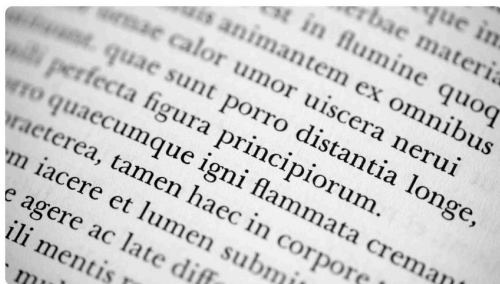
Here are a couple of examples.

First, from a blog post discussing useful books to learn Latin:

This book is recommended for intermediate-level Latin readers and higher due to the lack of grammar and vocabulary assistance.

If you're at this level of Latin knowledge, you will get endless joy out of practicing your Latin because you will not be reading the same book twice based on your choices.

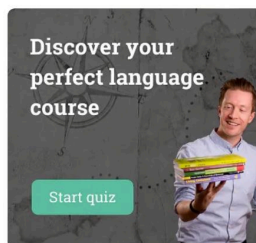
Books To Learn Latin



One of the biggest **reasons to learn Latin** is being able to read works from authors from all the way back in Ancient Rome.

As any language learner can attest to, things get lost in translations. Reading in any language, especially with dead languages like Latin, you will notice impressive gains in your language abilities. That's why reading stories is at the heart of the **StoryLearning® method**.

You will be able to easily read sentences and understand complex grammar that previously had seemed insurmountable. Grab one of these books and allow your Latin knowledge to grow!



[← BACK TO BLOG](#)

**Blog post, addressing:
“Why is this different?”**

Next, an email that's part of our automated funnels:

But this time was a surprise...



Email, addressing: "Why should I listen to you?"

(I'll explain this down below)

The people who asked me to prove my ID: Reddit.com

Reddit.com is the 6th most-visited website in the USA. "Huge" doesn't do Reddit justice. Reddit is the internet.

Anyway....

Not so long ago, Reddit invited me to do a public A.M.A. (Ask Me Anything) about language learning, for over 500,000 people. It was planned for 4pm on a Sunday afternoon. So I turned up at the appointed time...

Logged in...

And was immediately hit with a surprising question...

"Prove you're Olly Richards!"

The moderators were so worried about fakery, that they told me to prove that it was actually me logging on to the event that they had invited me to!

Lastly, a script for a [YouTube video](#) about the Chinese language:

But this happens in every language really, and they probably have the same complaint about us English speakers.

[VIDEO](#)

Know what they call a piranha in Mandarin Chinese?

A food people fish.

Yep, to a Chinese piranha, we're the same category as food!!

Chinese words don't always make a lot of sense if you translate them literally...

But if you read a Chinese STORY about piranhas, you'll never forget the word

Because you'll see the word over and over in context

Which is why at storylearning,

we teach Mandarin Chinese through stories

(more about this in the description below)

But before we move on

Let me give you a few more examples monsters for your dreams tonight

You may or may not want these to stick in the memory...



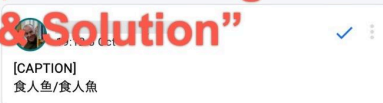
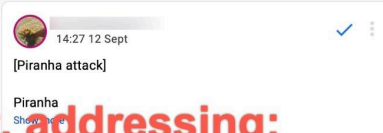
But characters and words are just the start.

Now you must learn to connect them to make phrases and sentences.

As a beginner, you're gonna thank your lucky stars for one little thing...

[VIDEO 0:00 - 0:05](#)

Video script, addressing: "Problem & Solution"



At the beginning of this chapter, I talked about how marketing and sales are often treated as separate disciplines, and hopefully now you can see why this doesn't necessarily have to be the case.

Once someone has been consuming our content over a period of time, they will have already internalised everything that you might expect from a traditional sales process:

- What makes this different?
- Why should I listen to you?
- Show me some proof!

And so, what we always find is that when it comes time to make an offer of some kind, the sale is *almost effortless* because they already know they want to buy what we are selling.

We often don't even need a sales page – simply sending someone from an email to an order form is enough, such is the level of trust that we have built.

It all relies on the DNA of StoryLearning being magnetic enough in the first place to capture someone's attention.

It's definitely a different way of doing things, but I'm sure the benefits are clear to you.

The other benefit of products selling themselves, is that there is no need for a sales team or virtually any kind of manual work in the sales process – our sales process is fully automated.

(Note that this also applies when we enrol people in our high-ticket programmes. Almost all of the "sales" work is done before anyone gets anywhere near an application form, and even then, we can close high-ticket enrollment with simple text messages, without the need for phone calls.)

This is welcome news for anyone who wants to maximise lifestyle, and remove themselves as an indispensable cog in the wheel of their business.

Summary

What you have seen in this chapter is a holistic approach to sales and marketing that builds a strong, stable business with a raving fan base that loves to buy from you. It relies on a simple content framework that drips out key messages in content over time, and makes selling an effortless and largely passive experience.

4. Offer Sequencing

In this chapter, I'll describe how we sequence and present the various offers in our ecosystem. Read this chapter if you want to sell more of what you already have, in a more natural and effective way.

So far, I've explained how world building works, and the philosophy I take towards sales and marketing.

Quick recap, in case you were caught napping: We have a world of different offers with a single theme running through them, and let people take up offers in their own time.

That's the high-level approach.

The danger of this approach, though, if you don't get it right, is that it leaves sales open to chance:

- What happens if people don't visit your website and find your offers?
- What if you rely on a launch model to sell your products?
- What if you have big seasonal ups and downs?
- What if people are just too busy to make a buying decision?

Despite what economists would have you believe, there's rarely anything logical about people's decision making at all, so you have to give them a helping hand.

When Charles Darwin was deciding whether to get married in 1838, he wrote an extensive list of pros and cons.

The cons were serious, and included:

- *Expense and anxiety of children*

- *Forced to visit relatives and bend to every trifle*
- *Fatness and Idleness*

The evidence all pointed in the direction of not marrying.

However, he concluded: *“Better than a dog, anyhow”*, and married his cousin, Emma Wedgwood the following year.

If the great Charles Darwin could be so immune to logic, you can be sure your customers will also be from time to time.

And so what we’re going to talk about here is a balanced approach – offering them the à la carte menu, waiting patiently for them to decide, but as soon as they get indecisive, whipping out the secret “chef’s special” that they simply can’t resist.

We’re trying to organise your business activity in a way that makes sales happen reliably and often. Do this right, and...

People will gladly buy again and again, without feeling like they’re being sold to, or even being asked to buy anything!

Now, this doesn’t come easy.

At first, you may well baulk at the amount of “selling” we appear to be doing.

I know, because I did.

For years, as a newbie, I suffered from chronic underuse of my email list because I didn’t want to “annoy people”.

I thought: "I don't want to email people too often or they'll unsubscribe".

(Go on... roll your eyes... it’s ok!)

Later it became: "I don't want to sell anything, or they'll think I'm a sellout."

When I finally started selling, it was "I don't want to send emails every day of the launch, or it'll come across too aggressive."

And then, when I was comfortable selling, it was "I don't want to make offers too often, or people will unsubscribe."

I'm relieved to say that I eventually got over all these newbie mindset fails, but it did take time. I think what got me over it was learning from others - being in the orbit of people who were more advanced than me.

That, plus realising that all those thoughts in my head were *just plain wrong*.

"I've had a lot of worries in my life, most of which never happened."
- Mark Twain

(Or was it really Mark Twain? Everything ever said seems to be attributed online to him or Einstein. Whatever.)

Here are some of the main things I think about when making offers within StoryLearning:

- People are busy and aren't paying attention
- Therefore, regular offers are necessary
- Use segmentation to make offers relevant to the right people
- Every offer must be unique and genuinely compelling
- Don't sell; issue invitations to buy
- The best way to do this is with genuine urgency and scarcity (e.g. "The cohort begins on 1st May")

I love creating "playbooks" like the list above. It relieves you of decision fatigue and makes business so much simpler, while keeping your own psychology at bay.

Even better if you can delegate the execution of this to your team, which we'll cover later.

Schedule of Offers

What follows is our offer cadence at StoryLearning – the way we sell all the stuff we have.

Remember that our Core Offer is Evergreen - meaning you can go to the website and buy it any time. So everything else you'll see here is happening behind the scenes, mostly over email.

Email funnel

Over email, to new subscribers, we sell our Core Offer via automated email sequences. Simple as that. Most people who come to the website aren't ready to buy, so it makes sense for the email list to sell that first.

After people have finished these automated sequences, they will begin to receive the offers below.

Who receives this? Everyone.

Monthly offers

We have two sales events per month:

- Mid month
- End of month

At mid month, we sell our Standalone Offers.

At end of month, we sell our Continuity Offer. (This provides natural urgency because challenges start on the 1st of the month)

A typical promotion would last 3-4 days.

Who receives this? Everyone except:

- People currently in the initial email funnel
- Recent buyers of the Core Offer
- People who already own the particular product we're offering

Special offers

So, on a typical month, we'll run the two offers described above. However, when there are special events of some kind, we'll just skip a month, to make space.

These special offers include:

- New product launch
- Seasonal promo (e.g. black friday)
- High Ticket cohort

Promotions for these events tend to be longer, up to 7-8 days, because they are more important offers that need more selling.

Who receives this? Usually, interest list only. (Sometimes everyone.)

You might notice that the Core Offer is never included in these promotions. It's actually quite rare that we do a sale for our Core Offer to the list. We do it from time to time, but honestly we've found that it never does very well.

My theory is that when people first encounter StoryLearning, the uniqueness of the brand and method means that people either jump at it straightaway, or not at all. If they don't buy early on (i.e. on the website, or in the main email funnel), it's either because they don't like it or can't afford it. If they don't like it, well it's not for them anyway. And if they can't afford it, we're also not right for them, because all our products are fairly expensive, and I don't generally discount. (In fact, I have a general policy in the business of never discounting, for this exact reason.)

Also, you'll see that we use quite heavy segmentation in order to control who sees what offer. Because of the volume of offers, it's really important not to send blanket promotions to everyone.

What we try and achieve is:

- You will only receive offers for things that are relevant to you
- Never for a product that you already own
- Also not for a certain period of time after buying something

So, in reality, as a regular customer, it is quite rare that you will receive an offer more than once every couple of months. The only people who will receive quite a lot of offers are those who have never bought.

For non-buyers, the philosophy is either we keep cycling through offers until they find something of interest, or else they are simply a non-buyer and will just enjoy all the free content we send.

Think of it like social media...

The price of using social media is to see ads. I treat StoryLearning in the exact same way!

I realise that all of this may sound like a lot, especially if you're not used to making regular offers. But I've noticed that things from the customer side never appear as intense as they do from our side. Not least because, remember, people simply aren't paying attention all of the time anyway.

Systematise The Cash

Like I said before, it took me some time to get here.

For the 1-2 years when we were building this offer cadence, we struggled to be consistent with execution. Sometimes we would simply run out of time - we'd be too busy to put out the offer. Other times, we just plain forgot. Or there was a miscommunication within the team. Everything is tricky the first time you do it.

We realised quite quickly, though, that we were shooting ourselves in the foot by not having systematised the very thing that brings in cash. So we went through a period of time of properly systemising this offer sequence. And herein lies a huge lesson:

The first things you should systematise in your business are the processes that generate cash.

Processes lead to reliability.

Reliability leads to cash.

Cash leads to stability.

Stability leads to growth.

We put a lot of time into writing (in advance) email campaigns for every single regular offer that we make. (Yes, this means dozens of email sequences.)

We built dedicated funnel pages that we could use, and reuse, every year for that exact same offer.

We hired for a role whose sole job it was to execute on these offers each month.

It was a lot of building, but the work we put into systematising this resulted in many \$100,000s of extra annual revenue – mostly pure profit – not from any new ideas, but just doing the basics well.

Once we had the offers automated, a couple of things happened.

1. We had large amounts of extra cash in the business.
2. The efficiency we had created meant we had time to move on to new growth areas.

And so this is a model that I'm always looking for in any business that I look at:

Where is there untapped revenue through inefficiencies, and how can we automate this?

Here in the UK, you often hear the government talking about “efficiency savings”, whenever they’re looking for extra headroom in the finances. And you immediately get a critical chorus of commentators and opposition MPs accusing them of trying to make cuts. But this is poor thinking, because efficiency in operations and systems is a very real thing, and the payoff can be huge if you get it right. Trouble is, in my experience, *inefficiency is usually the default in any system*. This means you need to bring real determination and drive in an effort to build efficient systems.

In a business, this starts with sales.

I shudder to think of the waste you get in big government departments. Probably the equivalent of the GDP of a small nation.

Everywhere I look in StoryLearning, so much of our growth has come from systematising revenue generating areas of the business, allowing us to move forward with extra cash and clean focus.

In case it's not obvious... a lot of this is not fun work.

The thought of writing dozens of email sequences and hundreds of funnel pages may fill you with dread.

Truth is, it's boring.

Building systems is boring.

But boring is profitable.

Summary

In this chapter you've seen how we structure and stagger our offers within StoryLearning. There is a combination of evergreen, publicly available offers, plus a regular cadence of monthly offers over email. We segment everything carefully to avoid overwhelming people, and build strong systems to ensure it actually happens.

5. How We Do Email

In this chapter, you'll see why email marketing is the lifeblood of StoryLearning and how we make millions of dollars through the sending of simple, mostly automated emails. Read this chapter if you want to understand email marketing better and make more money with email.

Anyone who tells you email is dead is just trying to sell you a different marketing method.

Simple as.

Email is just as important in 2023 as it was in 2002, and I don't see it going anywhere.

Your email inbox is like that Burgundy 1971 you have in the cellar – you ain't letting anyone near it who hasn't earned the right. (Or perhaps unless you really want something from them!)

Imagine DM-ing your lawyer on TikTok. Imagine submitting your mortgage application on Facebook messenger. Imagine talking to your mum on Slack.

There's only one reason that email might not work for you – you haven't convinced your audience that you've earned a place in their inbox.

Be valuable, be entertaining, be relevant, and they will want you in their inbox.

At StoryLearning, email is the executioner in chief.

Any and all important messages that we send out go out via email. Product launches? Email. Weekly newsletter? Email. Interest list for a new product? We build it on email. Cool new content? We email it out, of course.

None of this is to say that other channels aren't important, but if I were running out of a burning office, the one thing I would take with me is a USB stick containing a backup of my email list.

And that says it all.

(Although, the day you see me coming out of an office, shoot me.)

Think of it like this – for an education business, your lifeblood is your audience who wants to learn from you.

Your audience *is* your business.

Out of all the people in your audience, some will eventually buy. If what you make is good, people who buy will want to buy again.

Audience, audience, audience.

And the only reliable way to communicate with your audience is via email.

YouTube subscribers are great. Instagram followers, fine. Facebook groups? Nice to have. But anything on social media can and *will* eventually be changed.

Remember when Facebook pages lost 90% of their reach? (It was around 2015.) Ever had a friend have their Instagram account shut down? What about shadow banning on YouTube?

OK, that last one is just a conspiracy theory...

Point is, on other people's media, you are simply not in control of anything.

You're just renting space, for as long as they deem to rent it to you. And when they want to take back possession, they will.

And it will happen overnight, because in case you hadn't noticed... there's no contract saying you get to stay ad infinitum!

Email is different.

With email, you own the relationship.

You know your customers' names and email addresses – maybe even phone numbers. You can back up the list, export it, store it on the Cloud, and whatever misfortune may befall you in your business, you will always have these contacts available to reach out to, whenever you choose.

And the point about email is that you can reach out to them.

Tell me how you would guarantee your Instagram follower sees your new product pitch? You have maybe a one in 10 chance. Email? Gets through to them every time.

(Whether they pay attention or not is another question, but that's down to you. As is email deliverability – but that's something for another day.)

At StoryLearning, we have always placed a premium on growing our email list. Whether I've written a guest blog, published a YouTube video, or appeared on a podcast, the call to action is almost always to send people somewhere where I can capture an email address. Forget social media. Mostly forget trying to make a direct sale. Get the email, because then you own the connection.

Example of a typical email capture page we use. ([Link](#))

Here is how I see the fundamental job of email within StoryLearning:

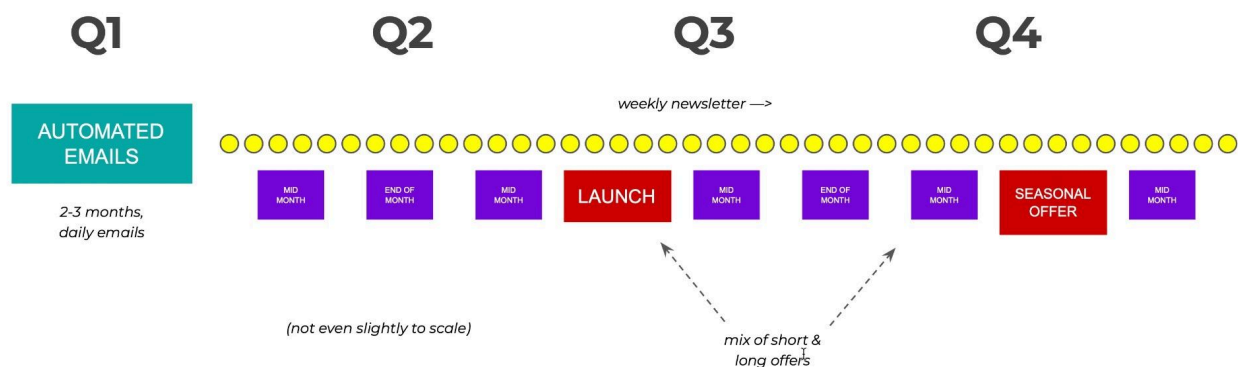
1. To grow the relationship with my audience through education and entertainment
2. To cement our positioning within the language learning space and keep us top-of-mind
3. To learn about our audience - feedback on ideas, interest lists, random back-and-forth
4. To help grow our other channels (e.g. YouTube channel or podcast)
5. To make offers

As you can see, this is a lot more than just selling. We use email for brand building.

To do this, we use email in three different ways:

1. *Email autoresponder* (automated emails) – new subscribers to the newsletter will get a 2-3 month automated email sequence designed to indoctrinate people into our world, repel the wrong people, and sell people into our Core Offer
2. *Weekly newsletter* – subscribers who have finished the automated sequences receive 1-2 newsletter style emails per week
3. *Product launches & sales* - promotional email sequences designed to sell something

Here's a simple version of how this might look over the course of a year...



I'm often curious how other businesses manage their email list. So, here are some specifics from me at StoryLearning...

Daily Emails

I remember my very first automated email sequence, back in 2013. I think it had one email per week. It was the most timid thing you've ever seen. My entire sequence was probably 20 emails, sending one per week, over the course of six months.

I was simply too scared to send any more than that, even though I wasn't short of something to say.

I'd once heard someone say "Don't send too many emails or people will get pissed off and unsubscribe!"

And I had believed it.

I mean, who wants to piss people off? I'm English after all... I take every opportunity to apologise to people, even when I'm doing them a favour. I'd probably apologise to HMRC for paying my obscene tax bill if there were actually any humans there to speak to.

I think most new online business owners hear the advice about "not bothering your list" at some point, and get scared.

But look...

If you've built an interesting business, with a compelling USP, in a great niche, with a unique methodology, and all the other stuff we talked about earlier on in this guide, then your ideal customer should want to hear from you.

Every single day.

I'm sure you have someone in your inbox whose emails you always open. What is it that separates them from everyone else in your mind? Whatever that is, that's what you are aiming to become.

And daily emails is how we do it.

Daily emails give you the opportunity to get your case out in full, and really describe the value you have to offer. Why do this in daily emails, rather than in one long email once per week? Simply because it makes you top-of-mind. When you hear from someone once a day, they become a feature of your life, like a beloved piece of furniture or Grandad's slippers.

Like when you binge watch someone's content on YouTube.

Like the radio host you tune into every day.

Like the cartoons or soap operas you used to watch as a kid.

Russell Brunson once told me about a friend in the dating niche, who sent five emails every single day. When Russell asked why he sent so many emails, he replied:

"When you're in a relationship, you won't care about my emails. But the moment she

splits up with you, you have such a painful problem, that I want to be the very next email that shows up in your inbox.”

A bit extreme, perhaps, but the psychology of this is instructive.

The lesson here is that, whatever problem your customer is trying to solve, you want to be the person turning up in the inbox every day, because those who feel the problem most acutely are the ones who need your help and will want to buy.

But there's a secondary effect here...

Sending daily emails will also get fast unsubscribes from people who aren't all that interested.

Here's a deep truth that I've realised since then:

People unsubscribing from your email list is a cause for celebration!

In fact, you should actively encourage it. Go further – goad them on. Dare them to leave!

This is a good thing, because what you are left with is a group of engaged readers, who love hearing from you every day. And this, in turn, creates wonderful energetics in the business, as everything you put out falls on receptive ears.

And I don't know about you, but I would much rather have a smaller list of really raving fans, than a huge list of people who don't really care. Whenever I hear people bragging about their email lists of a million people, I always think “Oh yeah, show me your open rates!”

As Buffett says, you can't tell who's naked until the tide goes out.

But if they can get open rates like this – one of our sequences of *daily emails* sent to *cold traffic from Facebook ads* – then I bow down before them and worship the ground they walk on.

I stopped breathing at 3am. Delivered Immediately after subscription.	55.2% OPEN RATE	2.5% CLICK RATE	17,795 SENDS	679 UNSUBSCRIBERS
What happened at 3am on the mountain... Delivered 1 day after last email.	48.4% OPEN RATE	1.9% CLICK RATE	16,983 SENDS	550 UNSUBSCRIBERS
Watch this YouTube channel to learn Spanish Delivered 1 day after last email.	45.0% OPEN RATE	6.5% CLICK RATE	16,237 SENDS	262 UNSUBSCRIBERS
How to roll your 'R's in Spanish Delivered 1 day after last email.	44.1% OPEN RATE	3.9% CLICK RATE	15,913 SENDS	176 UNSUBSCRIBERS
(1 of 3) From breakup to breakthrough Delivered 1 day after last email.	37.2% OPEN RATE	0.8% CLICK RATE	15,642 SENDS	263 UNSUBSCRIBERS
(2 of 3) From breakup to breakthrough Delivered 1 day after last email.	40.7% OPEN RATE	0.8% CLICK RATE	15,278 SENDS	216 UNSUBSCRIBERS
(3 of 3) From breakup to breakthrough Delivered 1 day after last email.	39.3% OPEN RATE	0.6% CLICK RATE	14,978 SENDS	211 UNSUBSCRIBERS
Prove that you're Olly Richards! Delivered 1 day after last email.	39.2% OPEN RATE	0.5% CLICK RATE	12,356 SENDS	172 UNSUBSCRIBERS
The crazy history of Spanish Delivered 1 day after last email.	39.3% OPEN RATE	2.0% CLICK RATE	14,404 SENDS	164 UNSUBSCRIBERS

And so daily email is the way we do things.

Storytelling In Email

I know everyone bangs on about stories, but there is a reason for that.

Take it from someone who's entire business is based on stories. Heck, the word "story" is even in the name.

Stories are an effective and entertaining way of getting information across.

If you've got something to say, telling it in the form of a story is the most likely way you will get someone to pay attention and actually learn from it.

Stories are far more memorable than pure information, and you want people to remember what you have to say.

I told you earlier about my origin story being stuck on top of a mountain in Argentina. Well, you have no idea how many people I meet who reference that story when they first meet me.

It always blows my mind. That just shows the power of a well-crafted story.

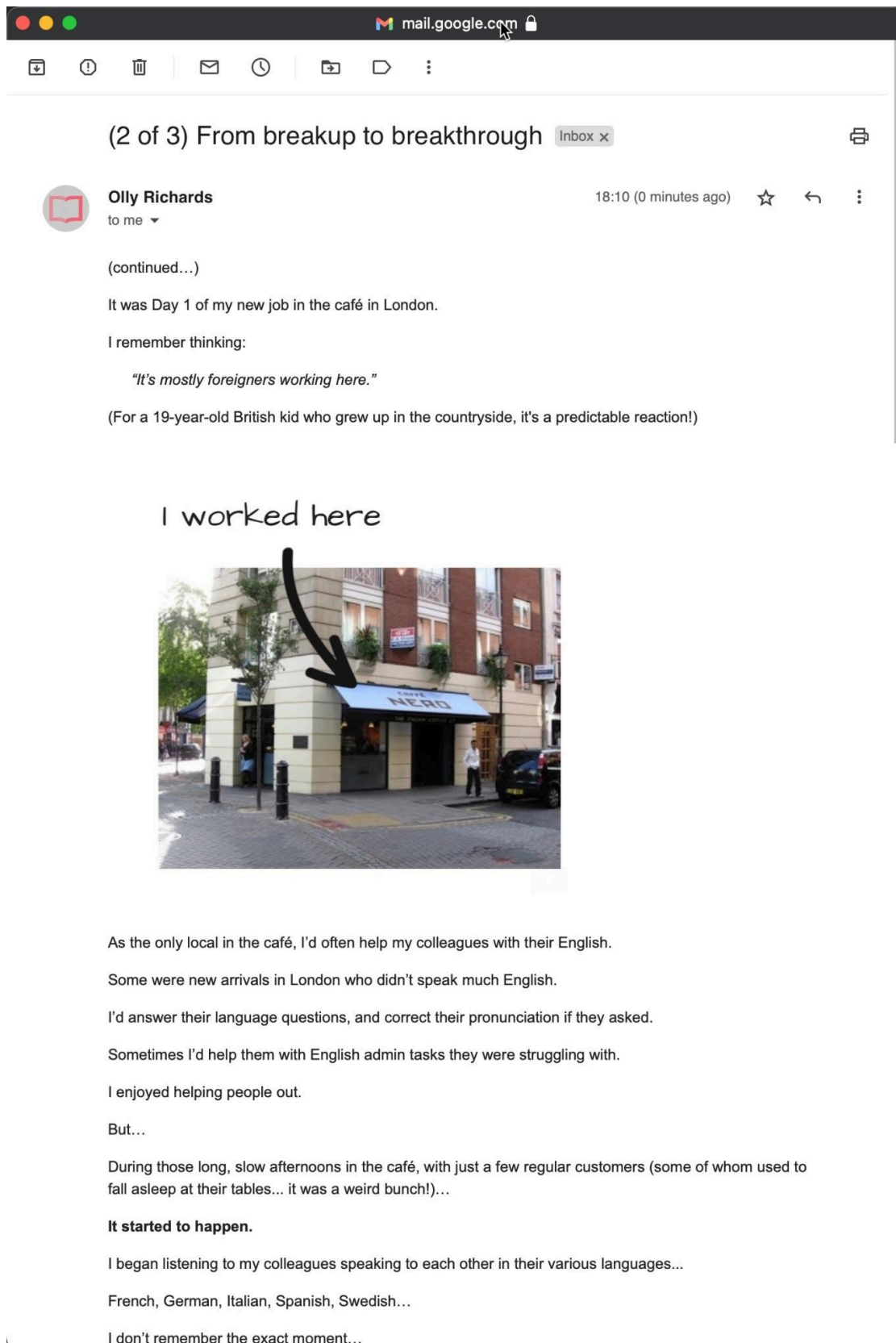
But the only reason they know that story is... *Because I tell it!*

You have to tell the stories in the first place, and tell them often. And that may sound like Captain Obvious over here, but people don't do it nearly enough.

Stories must be repeated, because as I keep saying, people are busy and aren't paying anywhere near as much attention to you as you'd like to think.

So, whatever you are doing, whether it is introducing yourself, teaching your method, or even selling, do it through stories.

Here's an example:



(Fans of the great André Chaperon will no doubt see where I developed my style!)

Content framework

I think there's a real art to writing emails that engage, entertain and inform.

A mentor of mine, Scott Oldford, once called this "entrepreneurial art".

It may be art, but it can still be learned.

When I first started my blog back in 2013, I had no idea how to write emails.

I learned it. And so can anybody else.

Over the years I have developed a sense for what people in my audience like to hear about, and what resonates with them. I've done this by writing emails, hitting send and reading what comes back. I've developed a sixth sense about what stuff resonates with people. And then over time, I've simply done more of that stuff.

It ain't rocket science. Really.

The time my emails received a real upgrade, though, was when we introduced a structured content framework into the mix, which I told you about in the marketing chapter.

Here it is again, for easy reference:

StoryLearning Content Framework:

- What is this and how is it different?
- What do I get from you?
- Where did it come from? (Origin story)
- Who is this NOT for?
- Problem and solution
- How does it work?
- Why should I listen?
- Logical urgency
- Proof, testimonials, case studies

While stories work well for building rapport with your audience and teaching new concepts, there's a set of beliefs you need to get across to your audience for them to be ready to buy, which may not make it in unless you make a point of it.

This is what is covered within the content framework.

The reason I needed the content framework as a tool, was because I found that those elements weren't really making it into the stories I would write naturally, which was a big missed opportunity. I have CRO guru [Mike Maven](#) to thank for this – as ever, Mike was able to see the things that I couldn't.

This stuff sits in that uncomfortable grey area between teaching and sales. We'd all be happiest if we could just teach all day long, but in reality, you have to bring some rigour into your work if you want to be able to properly influence the sales process:

Persuasion Framework



So the content framework exists to help me always be demonstrating the commercial value that StoryLearing has to offer, and why people should choose us to learn from.

If you go through any of my email sequences, you will find a big mix of stories, customer stories, references to media that I have appeared in, stories about the problem I am solving, and some more technical stuff that describes the method.

Through every series of emails that we send, we aim to cover each of these things in various different forms. I don't sit down and write emails mechanically based on this framework, but I do ensure on a global level that all of these things are present.

We didn't used to have this stuff in emails, instead confining it to sales pages. But since we added this to the DNA of the emails and content we put out, we saw a real jump in sales, because people didn't need to wait to see a sales page in order to know that they wanted to buy.

And this is one of the keys to natural selling.

The key to natural selling is when customers know they're ready to buy before they make it anywhere near a sales page.

But! This is a lot of stuff to cover over email? Over what timeframe is this all sent?

I'm glad you asked...

Loops

The concept of loops is something we've developed to organise our email sequences.

Here's how it came about...

For the longest time, our email system would look a little bit like this:

- We had an automated email sequence for people when they opted in
- After that, they'd go onto the email newsletter and receive a weekly email
- Every so often, we'd launch a new product and email would get all intense

Probably sounds familiar?

This is what you do naturally when you're building a business out as you go, and it works.

Here are the obscenely simple dynamics that make it work:

- Give a bunch of value
- Allow some time to pass
- Sell something
- Then carry on with the value

And so our automated email sequences for new subscribers basically look to replicate this model, just in a well-planned and automated way.

Now, what you see below is a massive oversimplification, but it explains the concept quite well...

- Loop 1 - valuable emails (2-3 weeks)
- Loop 2 - offer (4-5 days)

Well, this is awkward...

It appears you've stumbled up an ad break!

I really hope you're enjoying the case study. It's been an unexpected joy to get all my ideas down on paper, and put them out into the world.

I wish I'd done it sooner, really.

But here we are!

As you know, this is all free. But I would like to ask for a favour in return...

If you've been enjoying this case study so far, would you stop reading for 20 seconds and share it with a friend?

Drop them a whatsapp, an email, send a carrier pigeon... however you like to communicate!

Just send them this URL and tell them why they should check it out:

<https://ollyrichards.co>

Thank you – I do appreciate it.

Olly

P.S. And if you haven't signed up to the newsletter yourself, now would be a good time! Just click the link above.

- Loop 3 - valuable emails (2-3 weeks)
- Loop 4 - offer (4-5 days)
- Loop 5 - valuable emails (2-3 weeks)
- Loop 6 - offer (4-5 days)

What Goes In The Emails?

For the longest time, my basic doctrine with email was always to convey maximum value within the email itself. In other words, if you have something to say, say it in text within the email.

As soon as you make people click away in order to consume the content you want them to, you lose 95% of them.

So it's better to write good emails, and have people read the emails. And I still think that this is broadly true to the extent that email provides value as a marketing channel.

However, these days, many of our emails include links to videos and podcasts.

Here's why:

We discovered something very interesting when doing some large-scale testing of email sequences: When we sent people off to our YouTube channel (where we make very high-quality videos), podcast episodes, and even blog posts, we found that engagement on the email sequences soared.

Our email open rates shot up from the mid-20s up to the mid-30s or even 40% plus.

(This is sending to cold traffic, by the way, which is a ridiculously high open rate.)

Initially this was confusing, but then I realised what was going on.

As good as email is, and as practised as I am at writing engaging emails, when people *also* get to see me on video, or hear me on a podcast, they suddenly have a much more personal relationship with me.

After watching a few of my videos, when they *then* go back to read my emails, they are paying much more attention. Same thing with a podcast. If you can get someone to spend 45 minutes listening to you, there is a much stronger bond built.

In essence, I think this is a logical extension of building the strongest possible relationship.

- How can you be as "real" a person as possible
- How can you command as much attention as possible?

It's a pretty simple human question. But using multiple high-quality media properties to do this has proven extremely effective.

This also has a useful side effect – when you send people to your other channels, it also grows those channels.

New media channels are incredibly slow to grow, so if you are already acquiring leads through email, it really gives it a nice boost to send people (for free) to those other channels. Of course this works perfectly well in reverse if your main channel is YouTube, for example, but this is what we do, and it has become a really cool part of our approach to email at StoryLearning.

Emailing Existing Customers

This is one of the most important mindset things I've ever learned, and something I see very few people doing:

We put as much effort into emails to existing customers, as we do to non-customers.

So many people treat email as a way to sell, but...

Email is fundamentally a way to build relationships. And the most important relationships of all are with your existing customers.

So, once people have bought, we ask ourselves: What more can we do to improve their experience?

We call these emails to customers *consumption sequences*, and the main aim of these is to help them consume the product they have bought and get the most from it.

Think of it as after-care service, just like after you've bought a car.

The manufacturers who properly follow up with you – you know who they are, and you notice it, right?

I've heard that Lexus built their brand largely on amazing after-sales service. I've got no idea if this is true or not, but based on the abysmal follow-up I've received from Jaguar, it wouldn't take much to compete.

If you own a new car, pay attention to the stuff they start sending you after 1-2 years of ownership. You think they've forgotten all about you, but oh no. They're just biding their time. It's very instructive as to where they make their money and the "next actions" they really want you to take.

On that point, it's especially important to think about what customers *do not* receive.

We are diligent about tagging customers, and making sure that they don't get any emails that are intended for non-customers, or anything that might otherwise spoil their experience.

An example might be after someone has bought a course, we don't want them to get another pitch for at least a couple of months afterwards. That's not to say that following up is a bad thing (quite the opposite), simply that in our focus on long-term relationship building that I keep hammering on about here, knowing when to leave people alone is just part of the ethos.

I wouldn't like that myself, so I don't want it for my customers.

(Hear that, Jaguar? I loved my F-Type, but I really didn't need an upgrade every year.)

Summary

In this chapter, I've told you about our approach to email, the high-level philosophy of showing up every day and cultivating a list of people who genuinely want to hear from you.

You also saw how we structure our emails using a system of loops that delivers content at an appropriate pace, and in an organised and automated way. Lastly, you saw how we use email to grow other channels, and manage relationships with existing customers.

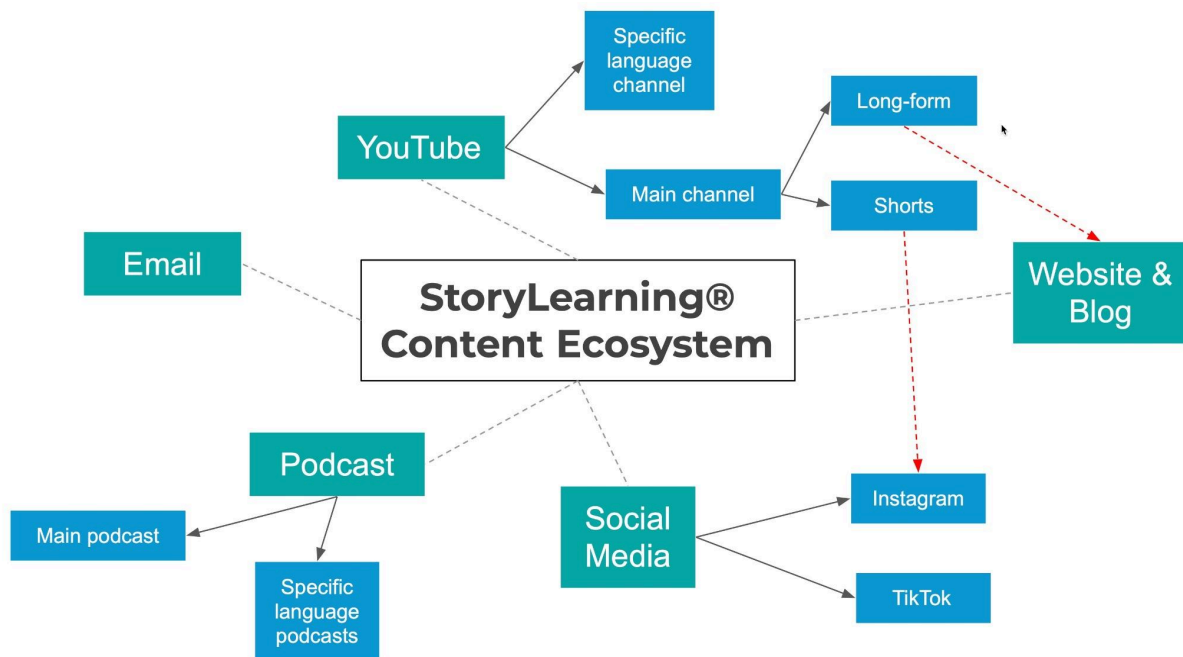
6. How We Do Content

In this chapter I'll describe the strategy behind our various successful media properties. You'll hear about the thought process involved, growth strategy and how we systematise production. Read this chapter if you want to build your audience faster with content.

Let's get straight into it. Here are all the places that StoryLearning receives website traffic from:

- Media we control:
 - Blog x1
 - Youtube channels x2
 - Podcasts x2
 - IG, Facebook and Tiktok
- Our email lists
- Affiliate partners
- Direct links from other websites (reviews, blogs, etc)
- Media (newspapers, websites etc)
- Customer referrals
- Books (online sales and in bookshops)
- Paid media (Facebook, IG, TikTok etc)
- Returning customers

First off, here is a map of all the main media properties that we control, together with some indication of how we think about them conceptually.



The reality is a lot more complex than this. For example, everything we create gets sent out in emails. The emails, in turn, send people back to other content. But short of drawing something that looks like it came from NASA, this is the simplest view.

How “big” is our content reach?

Well, I've always considered *impressions* to be a meaningless metric when it comes to the reach of content. I only care about meaningful engagements with our content, e.g. someone sitting down and actually reading what I've written.

What I consider meaningful for StoryLearning is the following...

- Our website receives in the region of 1 million hits per month
- YouTube another 1 million views
- Something like 100,000 podcast downloads
- And then a bunch of random social media activity which I pretty much ignore.

This is all just to give you an idea of the size we are working with.

To some of you this may seem big, to others it may seem small. I have friends with far more traffic than I do. And many with far less. It's all relative.

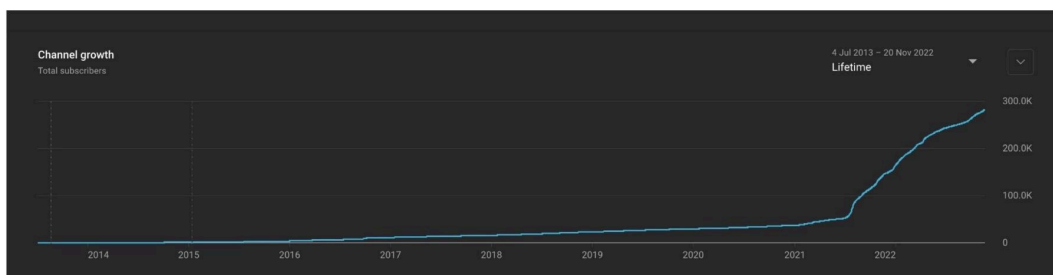
What I think is relevant is to understand that when it comes to growing content: Time is your friend.

Consistency over time – these three words are probably the most important words in content creation, but perhaps even in business overall. So let me say it again, this time in bold...

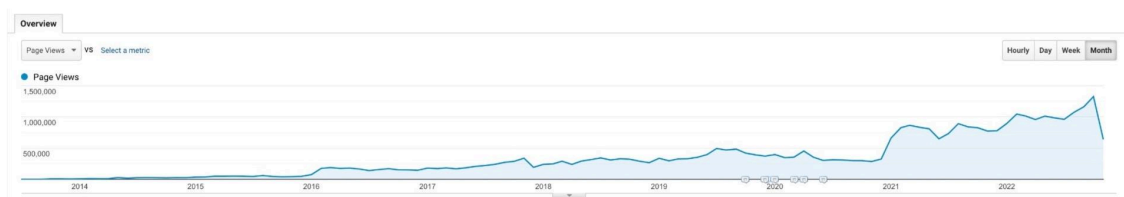
Consistency over time are the three most important words in growing a business

Below I will show you growth in our traffic between 2013-2022, YouTube and website side-by-side:

StoryLearning Growth 2013-2022



YouTube Subscribers



Website Traffic

They look different in some ways, similar in others, but there is an interesting story behind each one. We won't have space here to get into the details of this, I can tell you about it another time if you like.

Success with content comes down to consistency mindset – Do what you do, week in week out, and surrender to whatever happens next.

Because come they will... As long as you're doing the right thing. And great rewards come to those who stick at it.

(In case you're wondering, these graphs of exponential growth are pretty much the same with every single established business I know. The first few years are slow. Good things happen after that.)

Building Media

The overall purpose of our content is as follows:

1. Build each media property as its own unique project
2. Use each property to drive leads to the website
3. Capture leads on the website

To put a pin in this, the functional goal of content is to capture an email address. But you only earn the right to get the email address by building quality assets in their own right, and it's that part that we'll talk about here.

So, when it comes to making content, my fundamental belief is as follows:

With content, quality always wins over time.

I've always taken the approach to content of making the best possible piece of content in the world on that topic.

That inevitably means we make less content overall, but what I do make will stand the test of time.

At a simple level, this is because the various algorithms (Google etc) can monitor when people land on a piece of content, find it useful, and stay on the page. It's always going to be in their interests to optimise for this, and so I don't see any point in trying to make content that is less than the best.

The great Dan Kennedy said...

"There is no strategic advantage in being the second cheapest, so you may as well be the most expensive."

I take the same approach to content. So that's why we tend to go for long form, in-depth content, both written, text, video, and audio.

Sidenote — Why do you suppose this guide is so huge? I could have written a bullet point list on a one-page PDF. But I know that, for those who take the time to read it, this level of depth will be hugely valuable. It's also free. It *a*lso makes you more likely to share it. Come to think of it – can you do me a favour? If you have any friends or colleagues who you think would enjoy this guide, please text them my website and tell them to download the case study. You can copy this text if you like - *"Hey, take a look at the case study at <https://ollyrichards.co> – it's a pretty awesome example of how a successful online business runs."* Thank you – I appreciate your support!

Now, where were we...

Channel Building

The reason I say we build each property *as its own project*, is that every platform needs a unique kind of focus and has an algorithm that works in a different way.

You build a YouTube channel in a completely different way to a blog, podcast, or TikTok account. And that's why you really need a unique focus for each media property.

At StoryLearning, we have a team that focuses just on the blog, and a completely different team that focuses just on YouTube.

It's most definitely *not* what's become known as "repurposing" content - e.g. taking one video, chopping it up in as many different formats as possible, and blindly spraying it across social media.

For many years, in marketing circles, there has been a huge focus on repurposing content, but I think this is a huge mistake.

Repurposing is fundamentally lazy. I think we all know this, deep down.

But we do it because we think we can get "quick wins" by slapping our content up on every available channel and essentially syphoning traffic from as many places as possible.

This is very much bottom-of-the-barrel thinking, in my opinion.

(This is why marketers ruin everything!)

With just a little more effort, you can create content that is properly designed for each platform, which will then rise to the top over time.

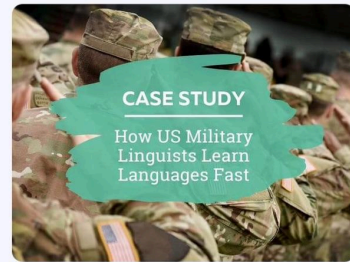
Important point here – This doesn't mean making *different* content, just *adapted*.

For example, we might begin a piece of content as a written [blog post](#), which is published on the website:

Blog

How U.S. Military Linguists Learn Languages Fast

by  **Olly Richards**



What if being able to speak a second language was the difference between doing your dream job or not?

What if it was the only thing standing between life and death for you and countless others?

If you're thinking, "Wow, Olly, let me at it!", perhaps you've got what it takes to study at the United States of America's Defense Language Institute in Monterey, California.

U.S military linguists are known for being among the fastest language learners in the world and they need to be good because in any number of intelligence-gathering or hostile situations knowing the local language can save lives.

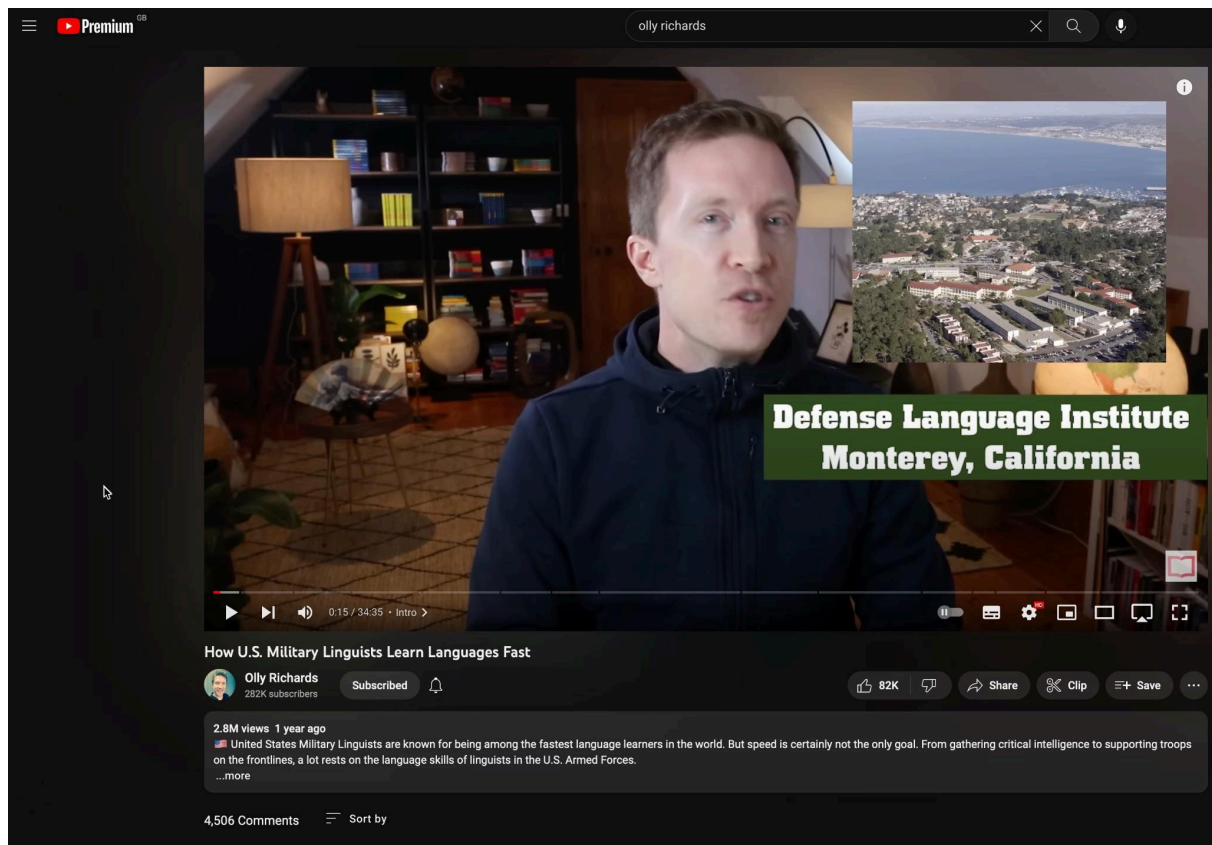
But you're probably wondering just how US military linguists learn languages fast. Well, in this post, you'll get an exclusive behind the scenes inside look at their training and discover how they get fluent fast.

Pro Tip



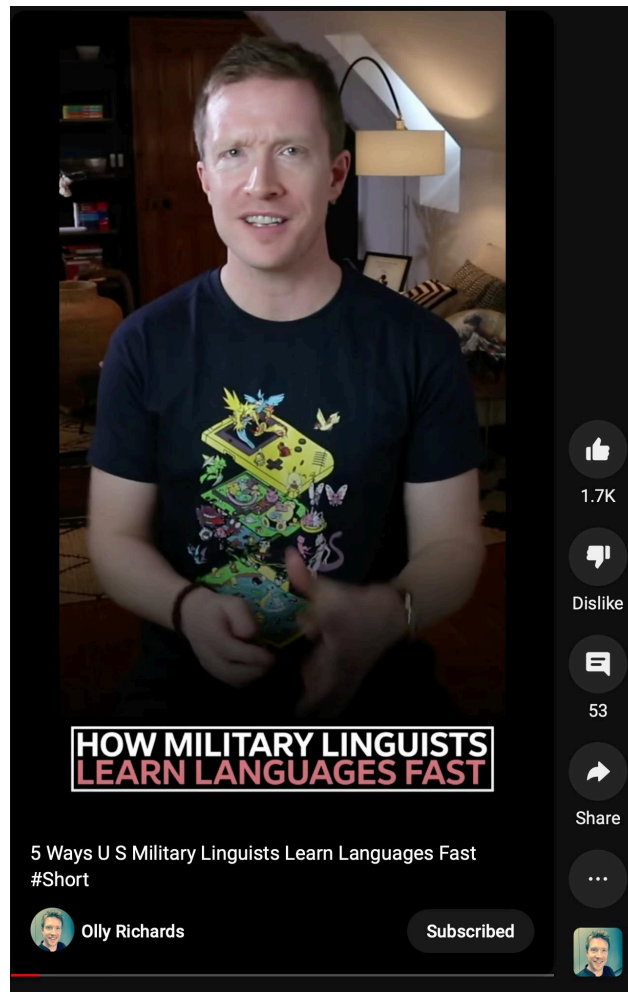
[← BACK TO BLOG](#)

When we come to make a [video](#) on the same topic, our script writer will take that content as a starting point, which saves hours and hours of work, but produces a distinct piece of work that has been designed for YouTube (e.g. carefully written intro, hooks in the script, teasers to keep people watching, more casual tone, pacing to achieve the length we want):



This video also gets embedded in the original blog post, which adds further value and leads to more views on the video itself.

After publishing this video, this same content will be taken and rewritten into various [short-form videos](#).



Note that each piece of content has been rewritten for each channel, based on our knowledge of what works on each platform. However, while the very first piece of content takes time to create, each subsequent piece is far quicker.

In a world where content is getting more and more competitive all the time, and there's even the threat of AI on the horizon, I still believe fundamentally that your biggest asset will be quality.

Put more love, care and attention and effort into your content than anyone else, and you will win.

(Sidenote - I recently recorded a two-hour masterclass on how I do YouTube. It's available free if you refer people to my newsletter. Check the referral section at the end of my emails for more info.)

Searchable Content

We also put a very strong focus on longtail searchable content.

Big keywords in the language niche, such as *learn Spanish* or *learn French*, are always going to be extremely competitive, because you will be competing with the biggest venture-funded companies (apps, in our case) on the planet who are all going after the same keywords.

It's a miserable zero-sum game.

So, it's usually in the longtail that you have your opportunities.

But more important than that is that your content be searchable.

Let's say someone has a struggle with German grammar. (If you know anything about German, you'll know that this happens to everyone, and will always happen for as long as people are learning German!) To solve their problem or answer their questions about German grammar, some people will go to Google, some people will go to YouTube, but wherever they are searching, they are going to type in a search query around German grammar.

What I then try to do with this topic is:

Make the best damn content on German grammar that I possibly can, such that people are still finding it in 20 years time.

This means that with every piece of content you create, you are creating a museum of stuff which lasts forever.

Notice how different this is from social media, where you make something and it disappears into the ether after five minutes.

This is why I never understand why people spend so much time building a social media presence. Not only is social fundamentally about entertainment (as opposed to learning or problem-solving), but the content disappears as soon as you have created it!

Sure, go ahead and exploit social media if you can find a way to use it to your advantage.

But an education business needs to create a library of information that is useful and relevant forever, and I think benefits from taking a more serious posture, which means creating in-depth, long-form content.

Brand Messaging

The other thing that you should notice about all our content at StoryLearning is that it is heavily branded.

I don't mean branded in a visual sense (although it is). What I mean is that we bake in messaging around “learning a language through stories” throughout the content.

Just watch any of our YouTube videos and you'll see what I mean – I might tell a story about a piece of language history, then use that to demonstrate the importance of stories, and then suggest that the viewer should try learning a language through stories.

I drop in bits of information and suggestions about the StoryLearning method and products all the time.

This is intentional and by design, because what it does is “plant seeds” in the mind of the viewer.

If you are seeding your brand messages into your content properly, it is impossible for anyone who watches a few pieces of your content *not* to become curious about your method and want to try it.

It all fits into the method I've been talking about throughout this guide:

- help people
- hammer on your brand messages
- be the one that shows up every day

This is what makes long-form, surgical content so powerful. It's not just that you are aiming for SEO brownie points... you are literally building a world which people can find and dive into.

You'll notice by the way that very few people bother to do this.

They're far too focused on short-term SEO hacks to bother to construct their own world.

But at StoryLearning we are at a point now where we have around 10 years of consistent content, all of which is on message, on brand, and working to our

advantage day in, day out. We are there and available for people to find in their own time. And whenever they find us, that's the beginning of the journey.

Now, of course, I didn't know this from the beginning!

I really started to understand the power of this from following various high-value marketers and observing why it was that I became hooked by their content. Why was it that with a select few people, it was impossible to spend more than five minutes in their world without being sucked in by their unique tone, voice and opinions?

Doesn't happen often.

But when you get really hooked on someone's content, you start devouring everything they do like a Great White on a feeding frenzy.

Once I understood the power of voice in brand, I started to see it everywhere in the brands that I admire.

Really big companies tend to do this really well, because they hire crack teams of world-class marketers to do this for them. But this is something that you can do perfectly well as a smaller company too, especially if you're the one writing or recording your content.

You just need to be crystal clear about your voice. (See chapter 1 if you want to revisit this.)

If you have a lot of existing content, this may also take a lot of rewriting, which it certainly did in our case...

After rebranding the whole business to storylearning.com and getting clear on our core messaging, we were faced with the gargantuan task of going back and adapting all of our past content to fit this new voice.

We had to go back and spend the best part of a year actually re-writing and editing old content in order to be really on message. (Thanks, Cara!). It was an expensive operation, but like everything with content, it pays you back handsomely in the long run.

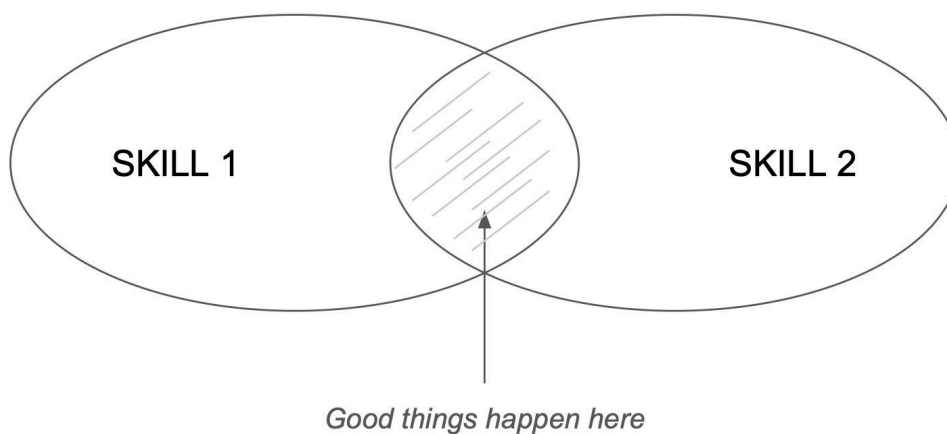
Books

Books are another part of the StoryLearning world which, while they don't contribute huge amounts of profit, are an integral part of our brand and world building efforts.

I began self-publishing books as an experiment back in 2014, after taking a well-known internet marketer's course on Kindle marketing, because back then I was still searching around for ideas while working full-time as a teacher in the Middle East.

I didn't do much with it at the time, but as soon as the story element of my language business began to take shape, I realised immediately that I already had the skill set to produce books.

Unfair Advantage



Seemed like destiny of sorts!

So, I spent the summer of 2014 writing my first book - a book of original [short stories in Spanish](#), and published it on Amazon myself. (It's surprisingly easy to do this by the way, in case you fancy a crack at it yourself!)

The book did phenomenally well, far more than I had hoped for. I think this was a result of having done a lot of market research - studying what was already available on Amazon and looking for ways to create new value.

Anyway, this book sold so well that I quickly started making more books of short stories, following the same formula in other languages. One year later I had five or six books that were selling like hot cakes, bringing in close to \$10k/month in royalties.

Quick sidebar – This is an example of piggybacking on an existing marketplace, a good growth hack and something I'll cover in chapter 9 on diversification.

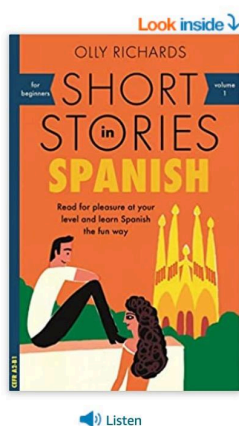
Now, where were we...

It was at that point that I got approached by publishers Hachette, who had been watching what I was doing and wanted to join forces on the series. The proposal was to work together to professionalise it, raise the quality, and add dozens more books to the series.

I was really in two minds about accepting this deal, because, despite being many people's dream to be traditionally published, my calculations showed that I would likely make less money than by continuing to self-publish. (It's just the way the finances of the publishing industry work... the money is in self-publishing.)

Anyway, despite the financial projections, I decided to go ahead with it anyway. The reason was that I knew that *impact* was a better metric than money. If the project went well, I could end up reaching more people than ever before, and that could lead to untold new opportunities – the kind of opportunities that money can't even buy.

It's one of the best decisions I ever made.



Short Stories in Spanish for Beginners: Read for pleasure at your level, expand your vocabulary and learn Spanish the fun way! (Foreign Language Graded Reader Series) Paperback – 4 Oct. 2018

by Olly Richards (Author)

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An unmissable collection of eight unconventional and captivating short stories for young and adult learners.

"I love Olly's work - and you will too!" - Barbara Oakley, PhD, Author of New York Times bestseller *A Mind for Numbers*

The series has done incredibly well, selling millions of copies, and is available in most bookshops around the world with even a shitty language section. This has brought 100,000s of new people into the StoryLearning world, and has become a very interesting and valuable new source of traffic.

What's interesting is that there's a certain kind of person that buys books in a bookstore, as opposed to searching for things on the internet.

People who read books tend to be smarter, appreciate quality and take their learning seriously. (The opposite of social media users.) It's the ideal customer we are aiming for with the StoryLearning brand.

The books don't really act directly as lead magnets, because we don't have huge, obnoxious calls to action anywhere in the books. However, the interesting thing that does happen is that...

- people buy a book on its own merit
- have no idea who I am (or even care)
- then see one of my videos pop-up on YouTube

It's at that point I get comments like *"Holy shit, you're that guy whose book I've been reading for the last month!"*

You can imagine how powerful this is as an introduction to the brand. If people have enjoyed the book, they need no convincing to check out the website, opt into the email list, or sign up for a course.

And even if they don't do any of these things, that's cool, because we are still growing our audience with books, and this will come back in many different ways over time.

All in all, it's a very interesting and impactful form of content.



A random pic from a bookshop in Thailand showcasing my books

In addition to these traditionally-published books, we also have a fairly big self-publishing operation at StoryLearning, where we experiment with different kinds of language learning books.

I won't go into much detail here, other than to say that, conceptually, I think of these books fundamentally as *content* (and therefore traffic sources), rather than *products* (to make money from).

Sure, our regular customers also like to buy our books, so it works both ways. However, fundamentally the role of books, to my mind, is to reach new audiences and bring them into the StoryLearning world.

How To Build And Scale Content

In the last few years, I've honed the craft of developing and scaling new content channels.

Here is that approach:

1. Keep your head to the ground and look out for emerging content trends in the industry. For example: The rise of YouTube in 2017-20, or the explosion of TikTok in 2020-22. It's hugely important to stay nimble and piggyback on emerging platforms with high reach.
2. Study the medium closely, by taking courses and learning from experts. Spend direct time making content yourself, learning how to do it, and gaining traction. (Embodied cognition)
3. Once you have traction, build a team around the content production method you have figured out. *Systemise, systemise, systemise*. The team then continues to build, while you gradually step back. Be patient, give the team space, allow them to make mistakes.
4. Continue to grow the channel into the future by allocating specific budget to it. Ultimately, think of your content as coming from the marketing budget. It should just eventually be a number on a spreadsheet.

Example:

Take my [YouTube channel](#). Because I'm the face of the channel (although not for too much longer), people assume I work on the channel full-time.

In reality, we have 10 people working on the YouTube channel in different capacities, and my total time investment per video is about 30 minutes, which is almost entirely filming.

Every single other aspect of the channel production is handled by the team.

This means that for a total time investment of 2-3 hours per month from me personally, we receive over a million video views, thousands of dollars in ad revenue, and tens of thousands of dollars in product sales.

It's a pretty good ROI.

When you're first starting out online, you should stick to one medium alone, and master that. It should also be the medium that you are naturally best at, so that you can shine and are more likely to stick to it.

That's exactly what I did, spending the first two or three years only blogging.

I'm sure that the reason my blog did so well was that I really invested my heart and soul into it. I took courses on blogging, I studied other blogs, I spent hours writing posts. I really went to town on the whole thing.

In my belief, you should stick to that one medium until you're at \$250-500k in revenue. Only at that point do you really need to think about reinvesting into different types of content. If your traffic isn't growing fast enough, get better at it. Don't divide your attention by starting something new.

Every business needs to establish traction before thinking about diversification.

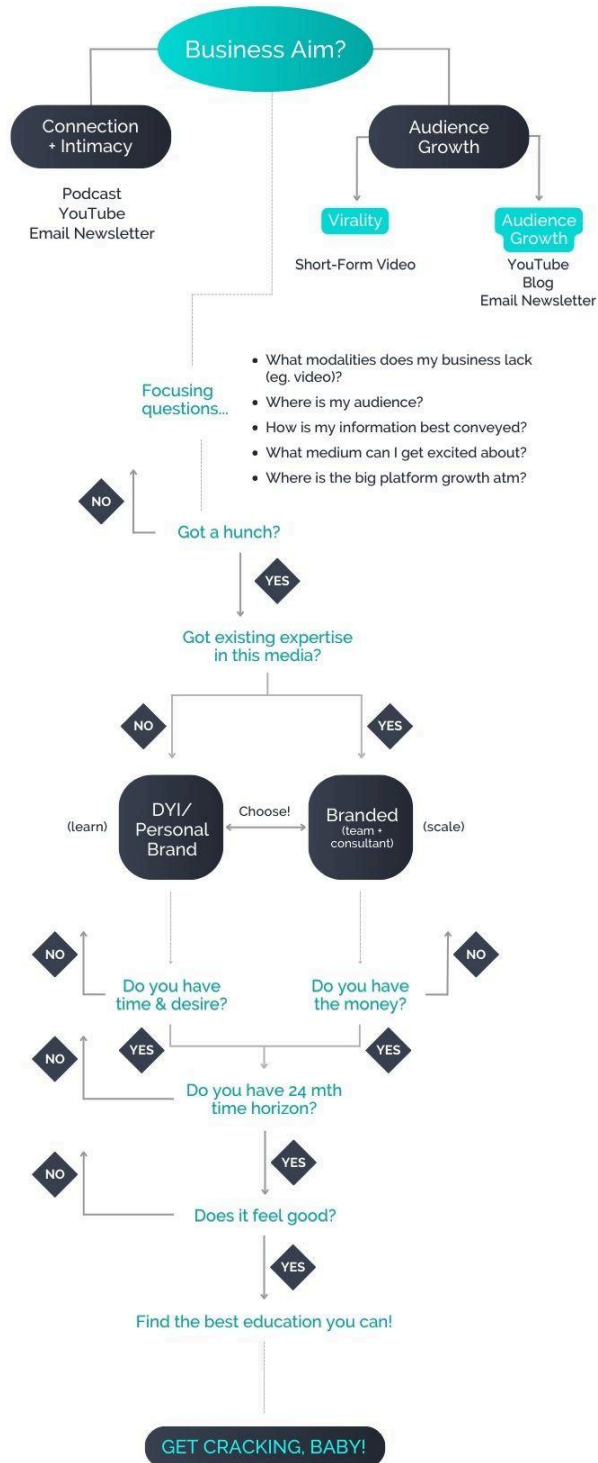
If I were to have one criticism of StoryLearning, it is that we are still too reliant on organic traffic. Sure, that traffic is spread among many different areas, but there is still a lack of control there which makes me nervous. That's partly why we are investing so much in paid advertising at the moment, but that's another story!

Media Property Decision Framework

Based on 10+ years of growing StoryLearning through content and media, I've created a framework for deciding where to focus your content marketing efforts.

You'll find the framework on the next page. If it's too small to view, click [here](#) to view it more clearly online.

MEDIA PROPERTY DECISION FRAMEWORK



OLLYRICHARDS.CO

Summary

In this chapter, I described how we go about growing our content channels at StoryLearning. I've talked about the importance of quality, and the importance of baking your brand messages into your content.

You also saw how time is your friend, and how the big opportunity with content is to grow a museum of world-class content over time.

Finally, you saw how I approach scaling content by building a team around it, systematising everything, and then eventually stepping back.

I left you with a framework for deciding which media property to build next.

7. How We Do Product

In this chapter, I'll describe how I think about product, the challenges that product can present to entrepreneurs, and how to leverage product in different ways to grow the business. Read this chapter if you have always suspected you could be doing more with your products than you are.

I think we face a unique challenge as educators or artists: We care deeply about what we do.

Our product is our art, and it can be difficult to separate yourself from this. Especially when it involves us teaching at the centre of the product.

However, when I look back over the last 10 years of StoryLearning, the clear direction of travel for me personally - where I put my focus - has been away from product and *towards* marketing.

Let me explain...

At the beginning, you have to create a great product. This is usually less challenging for us as educators than it is for other entrepreneurs, because of our subject expertise.

So, it's quite likely that your early products are pretty good right out of the gate. At any rate, they're unlikely to be complete junk.

You then spend a number of years iterating and improving the products. And you do that until you get to a point where your product is world-class.

Again, with almost every educator business I'm involved with, this is really the easy part, because the founders are better at teaching than at anything else.

Trouble is, once you've got a great product, you then come face-to-face with the challenge of growing the business.

"Build it and they will come" is rarely true.

So it's down to you to get them to come.

A great product has a central role in growing a business, to be sure. You could argue it's the single most important thing. (Read Growth Hacker Marketing by Ryan Holiday

for more on this.) However, unless you're operating in a high-growth industry like tech, or have built something truly unique and groundbreaking, you're likely to have to do quite a bit of heavy lifting on the marketing front yourself.

Simply because getting the word out is hard.

Not only that, but:

As a business owner, it is your sole responsibility to drive the growth of the business.

You simply cannot outsource this.

For this reason, your job inevitably ends up shifting away from product and towards marketing and growth.

It was exactly this way for me.

In the early years, I loved building an audience and creating cool products for them. I must have made five or six products until we landed on our main suite of language courses – our [Uncovered programmes](#) – which would become the flagship offering in the business.

I was really in my element, here.

Basically a teacher who loved teaching, relishing the challenge of creating an online version of my knowledge.

What's more, students loved it too, and we began to make a real mark in the language space.

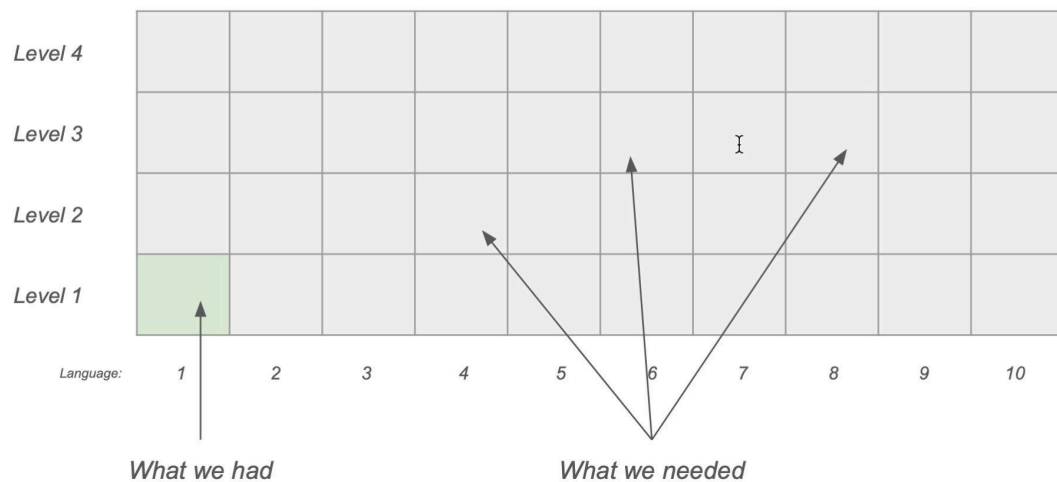
Once we knew we were on solid ground with the product, the task of growing it was actually quite straightforward.

You see, we had built this course only in one language.

It was an experiment.

Next, we needed that course in all 10 languages we work in. And that was only “level 1” of the course. After that, we needed levels 2-4 (representing beginner to advanced in the language).

Growing Our Products



Basically, we had a metric shit-tonne of building to do.

That would be the thing that really drove the growth of the business.

When I looked at the size of the challenge, I knew right away that it couldn't be me doing it. Not only did I not actually speak half of those languages myself, but it was just a colossal amount of work.

I knew that I needed to build a team to manage the creation of these products, and once that team was in place, my job would be just to step back and let them get on with it.

At the beginning, I'm sure I meddled too much. I wanted to see samples of teaching videos, look at the course areas, proofread the emails that were going out... Or even write them fresh myself. This was probably quite useful for the team at the beginning, just for learning and quality control.

But eventually, it was clear that they knew what they were doing (as if I needed telling!), and I just needed to get out of the way.

I think in retrospect I probably clung to this for longer than I needed to, because that was simply what I was good at. We always stick to what is familiar.

In fact, doggedly clinging on to doing what you're good at will slow you down faster than an Apple core iOS update on a Monday morning.

Anyway...

Most likely, you will not need anywhere near as many products as we have. You may even be good with one!

Reason I'm telling you this is because I know a thing or two about building and managing products.

So here's what I've learnt...

Managing Product

By far the best way to manage products and improve quality is by having a dedicated team. A team who can be on the ground, in touch with students on a daily basis, familiar with their comments, praise, questions and complaints, able to respond and full of passion to keep iterating.

It is a full-time job, and only works when you have full focus.

And that's precisely why you can't do it yourself.

If you are centrally involved in the delivery of the product in your business, don't be fooled into thinking you can't have a team pick up large amounts of the workload.

Even if you decide not to take on the challenge of replacing yourself in the delivery, there is still an entire ecosystem around the delivery of the product which doesn't involve you actually being on calls.

Everything from sales, to onboarding, to customer communication during the programme, to pre-recorded and written content, the curriculum itself, managing the community...

All of these are hugely important areas which you can approach with exactly the same mindset. That stuff definitely doesn't have to be you.

The first role you'll probably want to hire for is either a product owner or a customer success manager of some kind. And you'll want to have this person in place once you're making \$250,000 per year, and ideally long before.

Not because you can't manage the product yourself at this level (I know you're awesome!), but because of the opportunity cost of everything you'll miss if you do.

You need someone who can literally be in the weeds, ear to the ground, interacting with students, the first port of call for any problems, and the one who can spot problems and questions.

The main role of this person is to get you out of the day-to-day management of the programme itself - everything that doesn't involve delivery.

But it's also someone who can put their full focus on the programme and the students themselves, so that you can spot opportunities. Our products are undergoing endless iteration and improvements. We've actually changed a lot in recent years, from reorganising the modules inside the courses, to digitising a lot of the interactive quiz elements, to adding a student community.

All of these are initiatives that have been spotted and built out by our product team.

Whether this comes from comments in the courses themselves, the student community, emails from customers, feedback surveys, whatever it may be.

Ideas can come from anywhere. In fact, due to the quality of ideas that can come from customers, if you don't have a system to respond to them, then:

Business opportunities will simply slip through your fingers if you try to take on product by yourself, because your attention will be split six ways from Sunday.

This is also one reason to include product owners in management meetings.

Recently we had our product manager bring an idea to the table for an order bump for our flagship course, based on a pain point that kept coming up in our student group. It was a brilliant idea that none of us had considered before, and she even went ahead and built this herself which we're now selling on the front end.

And you'll see in the next chapter on the organisational chart, this is one of the big opportunities in building your team.

So many people I meet convince themselves that they can't manage a team, don't want to have a team, or whatever.

And as soon as I hear that, I know this person will never grow much beyond where they are now, simply because opportunities won't be spotted, and they will be too embedded inside delivery of the product in order to grow. Building a team of people who are familiar with all aspects of the business across operations and marketing in

particular, not only buys you back your time but also creates the foundation for growth.

Indeed, for a business looking to scale from \$2MM \$10MM, in every case the number one thing that needs to be addressed before that happens... is team.

Anyway, the reason I'm harping on about this is that I see so many entrepreneurs with a strong educational or artistic background literally cut off the blood flow to the growth of the business by hanging on for too long.

Your product needs an owner.

End of story.

Community

One of the big things we discovered during the pandemic was the importance of community within our programmes.

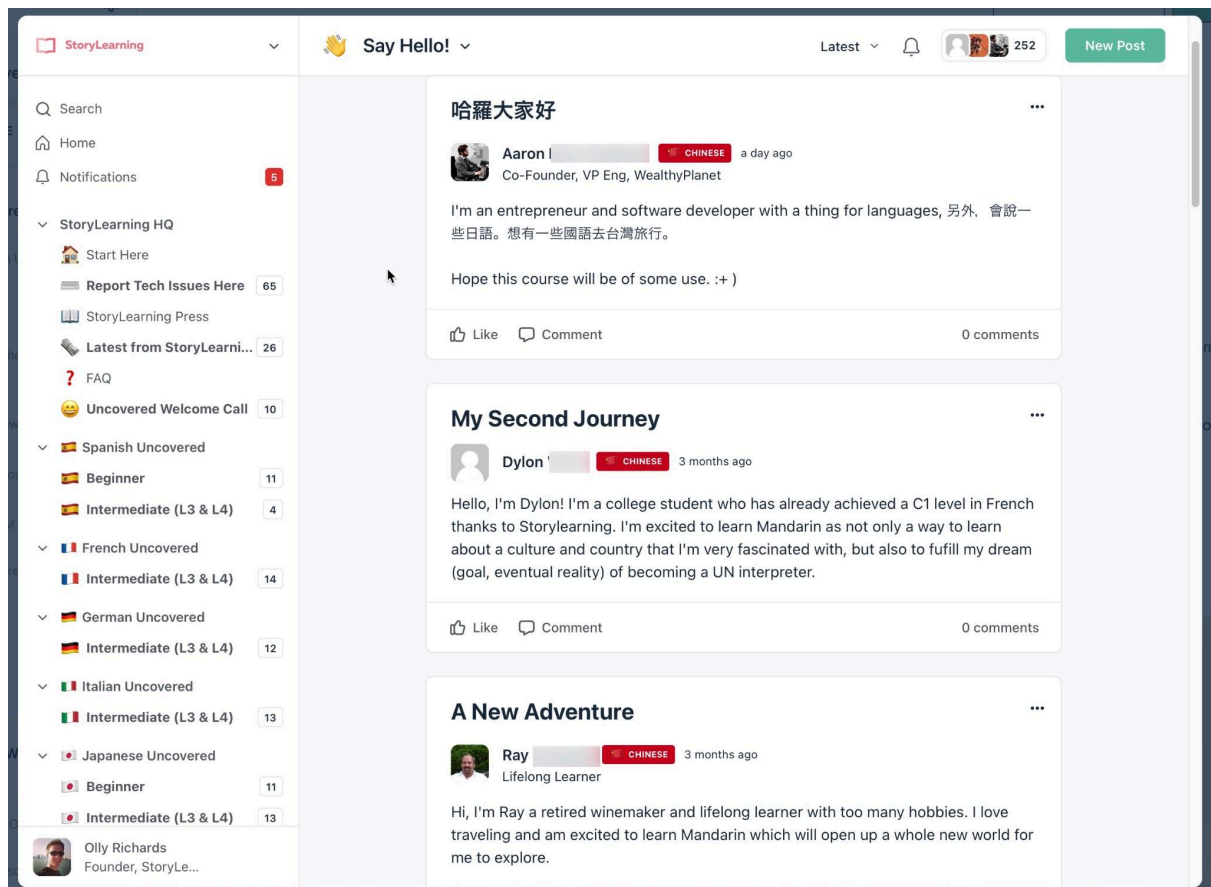
You might be rolling your eyes at this point saying, well duh! Community is important? *Who knew?!*

But I remember being so intent on building a super-passive business, that I never wanted a student community to manage... because... well, it's just more work!

But during the pandemic we experimented a lot with live groups and cohorts, to try and engage people while they were stuck at home in lockdown. What we discovered was that our whole student community came alive.

Students started to get to know each other, there was camaraderie being built, we started to receive unsolicited testimonials, natural group leaders would form and motivate each other. Students started having much more success at language learning (the whole point, after all!) because of the team spirit.

So after this, we started to bake community into everything that we do.



Community is definitely a very difficult thing to get right, and absolutely 100% needs a dedicated community manager, although this can also be shared with the product owner depending on the size and complexity of your business.

Apart from community elements that lead to better learning, one of the main reasons for doing this is that it just creates a phenomenal feedback loop between customers and the business.

You will hear directly about things that people don't like, and this can be scary.

In fact:

Adding a community to your products is likely to cause you a lot of pain at first!

But providing you have the resources to actually act on this feedback, it is the single fastest way to improve your products and continually improve the student experience.

And overall I have found that having a team that is focused on product, tasking them with listening to student feedback, and then, most importantly, empowering them to

take that feedback and make direct changes to the product themselves, has been one of the best things we have done.

Our programmes have improved way beyond anything I could ever have done myself, thanks to having this in place.

In the last chapter I talked about how I build an autonomous team to manage and grow a content channel.

I take exactly the same approach with product.

With every main area of the business, I want to make it so that it can improve and grow of its own accord, even if I'm not around. This doesn't always happen naturally though, because it's natural for team members to be nervous about taking the initiative.

We are lucky in that we have a very proactive product team, who I sometimes have to pull back from implementing new ideas!

But if you have a hunch that your people are not quite so proactive, it's really important to explicitly let them know that they have the power to suggest improvements and even make them themselves, and that you support this.

Business owners often don't do enough to let team members know that they have your support and that you encourage them to experiment, and yes that includes making mistakes.

A great leader always empowers their team to try new things, and then gets out of the way so that they can do it.

Product and Sales

The other thing that's important to understand about product is its role as a key sales tool.

There are many important pieces that you can put in place within your product, that will, in turn, help your sales hugely.

One example is up-selling within your products.

Our main courses, for example, I designed in levels from 1-4. At the very end of each level, once a student has completed it, we give students an offer to upgrade to the next level.

Sounds simple, but a lot of people don't do it.

Much of business is simple.

It's just about thinking about the next logical step.



🔒 PRIVATE: 🔒

This offer is for Korean Uncovered (Level 1) students only!

Enrol in Korean Uncovered (Level 2) Today... and Save \$50!



Congratulations on completing Korean Uncovered (Level 1)...

By now, you already have a rock-solid knowledge of the fundamentals of Korean.

You should be proud of how much progress you've made after only a few months!

But that's just the beginning...

You see, completing Korean Uncovered (Level 1) has taken you up to pre-

A lot of the time, the challenge with making offers to people is having a *reason* for doing it. If you have a good rationale for making an offer (for example: It's Black Friday!, or Our prices are going up next week!), it makes it so much easier to sell.

We've found that one of the best possible times to make a sale is when someone has just finished your product. They feel a sense of achievement, and they don't want to stop their learning there.

Look for natural “progress points” within your programmes to make an offer to upgrade or buy a complementary offer.

Next is testimonials.

If you've done a great job of building your products, and have happy customers, the most important thing to do with that is to put those happy customers in front of people who haven't bought yet.

Ever tried selling a product without testimonials?

I wouldn't recommend it.

People aren't sure if your product works. They want to know that there are other people in the programme and not just them.

Ever walked past two restaurants – one empty, one full? Which do you choose?

Dan Kennedy used to tell his dentist clients to have cars permanently parked in the parking lot, in order to signal to prospective customers that there were other people in the building.

(A lot of Gen Z'ers think that the term “social proof” was invented by Instagram gurus... but if they only looked up from their phones for 5 minutes they'd see this in action literally all around them.)

So it's literally impossible to have too many testimonials surrounding your products.

Two great ways you can facilitate this:

- Direct testimonials from customers
- Case studies of successful customers

For testimonials, I like to email people directly after 2 to 3 weeks of having signed up.

We sent people directly to a software tool called [Endorsal](#) that collects testimonials, asks for a photo, makes it look pretty etc.

We will also add this at the end of products, where people are most likely to be happy.

Automating this is really key, because you'll be amazed how many testimonials you collect over the period of a couple of years. They should then be plastered all over everything you do, to Timbuktu and back 17 times.

(You can see good examples of this on any of our sales pages.)

Similarly, when you have identified really successful students from within your student community (again this is why it is important to have a community and a community manager), you can approach them and ask them to tell their story.

Get on the phone, ask them to tell the story of their experience, and talk about how their life has been impacted by your product.

Stories, stories, stories.

Record it, publish it on your [podcast](#).

Then write it up and make a [case study on your website](#).

Email it all out to people and put it in your sales sequences.

This is classic “middle of funnel” (ugh!) content that can help the sceptical buyer understand the real value of what you do, and persuade them to join.

The only way you're going to identify these people, though, is within your product community, so that's why we take it so seriously.

Summary

In this chapter, I've described how an educational product sits within the overall business. On the one hand, there's the danger of clinging onto product yourself for too long. On the other, there are the myriad opportunities available to you by having product properly managed. These include feedback from a customer community, upselling customers, and collecting testimonials and case studies.

8. The “8-Figure” Team

In this chapter, you'll learn about building a team that can run and grow the business (not the same thing), plus a role framework we've used to enable this scaling past millions in revenue. Read this chapter if your business is over-reliant on a few individuals.

I've had many business coaches over the years - some from the online world, and some from a traditional business background.

It's very interesting to observe the differences between these two types.

To generalise horribly, coaches from a traditional background tend not to have a clue about the dynamics of the online world and the opportunities available to those who work inside it.

They do, however, tend to be super helpful when it comes to organisational challenges. Finance and HR are two areas that come to mind. (Interestingly, it's here that your typical online coach tends to be clueless.)

I think the reason this dynamic happens is that (generalising again), a lot of young online businesses are able to generate quite high revenue and profit, often in the six-figures, with little-to-no business infrastructure at all. A few assistants, perhaps. Maybe an accountant.

Whereas traditional businesses dealing with inventory, staff, or premises typically need to build a substantial infrastructure to achieve that level of revenue, which in turn requires the founder to have a strong grasp of finance from the start.

Online entrepreneurs usually never learn about serious finance or team building until... well, until it becomes an unbearable pain that dogs them every waking hour, at which point they desperately seek out consultants and agencies to remove the pain.

Been there, done that.

It hurts.

Nothing spoils a beautiful 6am walk faster than stressing over credit card bills, unpaid invoices and tax demands that seemingly come from nowhere.

So, in this section we're going to talk about hiring and team building.

Roles vs Individuals

StoryLearning has been built by the team, and couldn't have been done without the team. And yet when I look around at other online businesses, they rarely have the level of team that we've built out.

Honestly, I'm very proud of our team, and our annual company retreat (held at a luxury villa in a random tropical country) is always a wonderful experience when everyone comes together.

At the core of team building is the organisational chart, or 'org chart' for short.

Of course, I always knew what an org chart was, but I never thought of applying it to StoryLearning. It seemed like a big corporate thing that you needed to keep track of who everyone's boss is. It seemed horribly impersonal. Rather, I preferred to think in terms of all the wonderful individuals in the team.

And this was problem #1 - thinking in terms of *people* not in terms of *roles*. (More of that later.)

Anyway, what I never understood was the relationship between the org chart and the company vision.

I was at a point that I described in the last chapter, when I had a few people on the team, and had finally fired myself from the role of product manager.

I was thinking about how to grow the business, and knew that marketing was the big challenge. I was talking with my friend and coach, [Eric Partaker](#), and he asked me a transformational question:

"What would the \$10 million version of StoryLearning look like?"

This question upgraded my thinking about business in an instant.

I went away and thought about what the business would be doing at the \$10m level, and sketched out the imaginary org chart.

Of course, most of this was guesswork, but it got me thinking about roles – not individuals. What roles would be needed to fulfil what functions?

See, when you rely too much on people, things get personal. Will they want to do this? Will they like that? How will that affect our relationship? This happens when our businesses are small, because we often over-rely on certain individuals to run key parts of the business. (If that's you, you know who you are!)

But this doesn't work as you grow. Beyond the \$1m mark, reliance on individuals will kill you, because a business needs to work on systems, not personalities.

(Human beings, it turns out, are unreliable.)

A great example of this is what we talked about in chapter 7 on product. You can keep an eye on product yourself for a while, but it's only with a full focus on a customer community and feedback mechanisms that you can really discover shortcomings in product and improve it accordingly. Underresource this for too long and it's only a matter of time until the wheels start to come off.

Anyway, one of the things I learnt from this exercise is that a business can be seen as having three main functions:

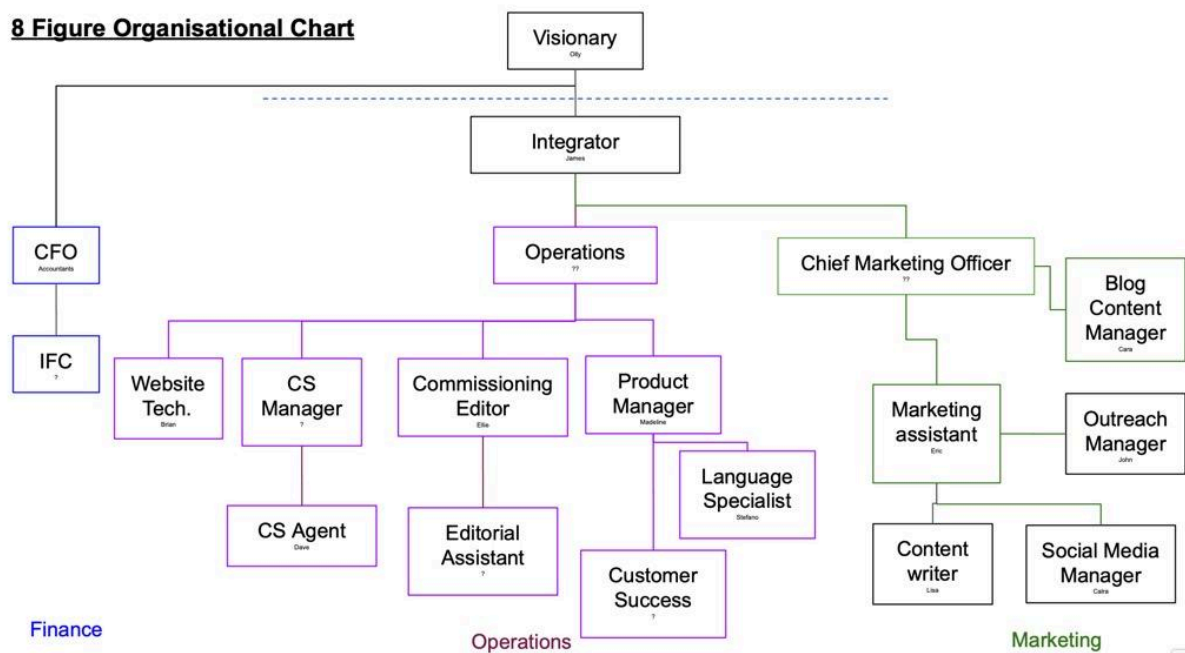
- Finance
- Operations
- Marketing

I drew these out, starting with the roles.

Then, I added names to each chapter – who was filling in for those roles *currently*.

This was my first draft at the time. Not particularly accurate at all, but gives you an idea of what it looks like:

8 Figure Organisational Chart



Sidenote - if you're wondering what the "visionary" and "integrator" terminology is all about, I recommend reading the book [Rocket Fuel](#).

As soon as I wrote in the names for who was doing what, I immediately saw that myself and my head of operations were basically wearing 4 or 5 different hats each.

For example, I was CEO, but I was also present in the YouTube channel, doing copywriting, even creating some of the products and overseeing all finance functions. It highlighted how thinly spread I was across the whole business.

There were a number of other staff in this situation too. By looking at the eight figure org chart, I started to see how our roles would need to separate and focus in order to grow.

So, over the next few years, we hired very intentionally to do two things:

1. To fill new roles that we needed to grow
2. To enable people already in roles to focus better on those roles

For example, our head of operations was heavily involved in marketing, setting up funnel pages, preparing email sequences, etc.... all while also overseeing everything else on the operational side of the business.

We could see clearly on the piece of paper in front of us how this was cutting off the blood flow to the brain of the business. So we immediately hired a marketing assistant who could pick up the slack on these various marketing functions.

At this point, I had learnt that you have to:

Hire before you need it, or you will choke off growth before it has a chance to happen.

We could see that, although we weren't experiencing huge pain just yet, the pain was clearly visible on the horizon and would be here fast if we wanted to try anything new.

This is a big lesson I've learnt over the years, and something I try very hard to do – identify upcoming bottlenecks in our strategy, and put people in place to alleviate them early.

Putting people in place early makes sense from a strategic perspective, but it's also necessary because people take time to settle into roles. In my experience it's usually a minimum of six months before a new full-time hire really understands their role, and more like 12 months until they can begin to take ownership and start to innovate without you.

It can feel a little bit uncomfortable for cash flow to hire early, but if you have a clear vision of where you're going, it's essential.

And where does that vision come from?

The org chart.

Do you see why this is so important now?

So here are some quick things I've learnt about the org chart...

1. Think in terms of roles, not individuals. (This creates a clear vision for the future and stops you becoming over-reliant on individuals)
2. Think about your business in terms of finance, operations, and marketing. Most likely, unless you're already doing north of \$2 million per year, or else carry lots of staff (e.g. agency) or inventory (e.g. FBA), you probably don't have much of a finance team. But... you will, so better to start thinking about it before it starts to keep you up at night.
3. Be honest about which roles you are covering yourself right now. Which hats are you wearing? Write your name in those boxes, and then commit to getting yourself out of them.
4. Ownership - make friends with this word, it's a key ally! As you build out the business, you must design the org chart to support that growth. This means making sure that each important function has an owner. When someone owns

a project, there is accountability. Where there is accountability, there are incentives. Where there are incentives, there is energy. Where there is energy, money soon follows

Who To Hire

My approach to hiring for StoryLearning has always been:

Hire for aptitude first, skills second.

I want people who are motivated and passionate about what we do – it's impossible to train for this. They either have it or they don't.

Skills, on the other hand, can generally be trained for.

Sometimes we do bring people on with significant experience or expertise, but generally we are hiring for people who are a good cultural fit and who we think will be with us for the long term.

This also makes for a lower cost base that keeps the finances much more balanced as you grow.

You'll notice that this is in direct contradiction to standard advice which is to *"Only hire A-players, man!"* You can certainly hire A-players if you want to, but realise what you're letting yourself in for, and know what game you're playing.

In line with the brand ethos that we talked about at the beginning of this guide, and the unique positioning we are trying to cultivate, I really don't want cowboys coming in and riding roughshod over everything we have built – culturally or technically.

As I'm building a business for the long-term, these need to be people who are in it for the long-term too, and I'd much rather go a bit slower with the right people than go on a costly ego trip with "rockstars" who care more about their career than your timelines.

Consultants

With all that said, my approach to team building does mean that you'll run into knowledge gaps as you grow:

- “I know we should do TikTok, but don’t know how.”
- “My sales page sucks, but I can’t write copy.”
- “I should probably sort out my SEO.”

This happens to us regularly.

So, alongside building our team of passionate, enthusiastic people who are in it for the long-term, I also make judicious use of consultants for specific areas of the business where I know we need to grow.

Consultants are industry experts who (supposedly) have deep knowledge on one particular area. You bring them in like a kind of hit squad, to impart their knowledge and expertise on one particular project, which saves you a lot of time as you don't need to build your own team around it.

You can bring them in, benefit from their work, get the results, job done. What's not to love?

Well, they're expensive.

I don't love that.

But a good consultant is worth their weight in gold, and can save you years of frustration trying to get something done with a team trying to figure it out from scratch.

Now, consultants need to be used sparingly. I've seen people make the big mistake of building their entire business around consultants, who essentially become very highly-paid staff, and I think this is a big mistake because it's not sustainable financially.

I would much rather place a premium on building a team who can grow together and build a strong and stable company over the long-term, even if that means going slower. But, by using consultants, you can speed up the process by “buying in” the knowledge you need at key points.

I've used consultants for:

- CRO (conversion rate optimisation)
- SEO strategy
- YouTube growth strategy
- And more

Generally, my approach is:

1. Understand the problem you're solving, or the knowledge deficiency you have
2. Tackle the problem with a highly-experienced consultant and pay them whatever you have to
3. Learn the lessons and bring knowledge in-house to continue with your team

I won't spend any more time on this, but I thought it would be useful to talk about the strategy of growing our team in this kind of tandem way, between long-term team and strategic consultants.

Hopefully this will help you think about your growth plans and skills requirements. You should build a team that is with you for the long-term, but that doesn't mean you have to go without the expertise you need to grow.

One last thing. Like I said before, consultants can be extremely expensive. However, I will say that the money I've spent on consultants has often been among the best money I've ever spent, precisely because they came with skills that were beyond my current level. Providing you are using consultants to help with very real and important problems (not tinkering around the edges), the knowledge and speed you get for your money make it all worthwhile.

Summary

In this chapter, I covered the importance of the organisational chart in developing strategic thinking in your business. We talked about thinking in terms of roles, not relying on individuals. Finally, we talked about building a long-term team in line with your values, and how to compensate for any skill deficiency.

9. Diversification (And Why Not)

In this chapter, you will learn how I have diversified StoryLearning in multiple ways as the company has grown – business model, revenue streams, investments and more. Read this chapter if a) you are always battling “shiny object syndrome”, or b) if you already generate \$1m+ with one business.

I personally think that a lot of nonsense is spoken about diversification.

In the personal finance world we generally hear about diversification as a way to be safe.

“Don't put all your eggs in one basket.”

“Spread your risks.”

This is a classic example of the scarcity mindset – avoid loss, rather than go for gains.

For personal finances this makes perfect sense. You are saving for the long-term, have very limited upside from traditional investments, perhaps have a family to provide for, and so must avoid calamities at all costs.

The entrepreneur should think of the word *diversification* in a very different way.

Here's my view in a nutshell:

- Don't even think of diversifying your core business until you're making at least \$1 million per year
- Between \$1-2 million per year, start diversifying
- Actively diversify your business model from \$2-10 million

Part of the reason that I can say this with some certainty, is that I did not follow this advice myself.

I started diversifying far too soon in StoryLearning, and this held me back.

Luckily, a lot of my diversification experiments actually turned out really well, but that was more luck than judgement.

The fundamental reason you shouldn't diversify as a new business is that you have yet to prove your business model. Any online education business should be capable of reaching \$1 million a year in revenue with a very simple product offering - one product, one funnel.

If you're not there yet, then it's either because you haven't nailed your business model, haven't built the right team, or have somehow failed to gain traction through traffic or audience.

If you have any of these issues, then diversifying won't help you grow.

In fact it will make it worse, because it will take your focus off doing the basics well and fixing those problems.

In essence, a new business needs to prove its worth before it makes sense to diversify. Given that diversifying is essentially a downside protection mechanism, you need to have something to lose before it's worth doing this.

The figure of \$1 million in revenue is useful because it's difficult to get to \$1 million a year without having the fundamentals in place, so it's a kind of shorthand for knowing when you have reached real traction.

You can reach six-figures in revenue with a good idea and a healthy dose of elbow grease. Seven-figures requires structure and team in all but outlier cases.

I think new entrepreneurs often get lured into diversifying because they don't know how to grow. That's why you see people with so many side-hustles. But side hustles are for people with jobs who want to earn a bit of money on the side. Side hustles are not for people focused on growing a new business.

Think of it like this...

**If you actually knew how to grow faster, you wouldn't waste any time
“diversifying”**

In my case, my diversification experiments were because I was stuck and didn't know how to grow.

They were a call for help.

I started a podcast, I messed around publishing Kindle books, I started endless blogs on the side. (Some very funny stories here, by the way. Ask me about them if we ever meet.) I started a live event side hustle of sorts, dabbled in teaching blogging...

The list goes on and on.

And when I look back now, it was 100% because I didn't have the knowledge I needed to grow. Instead, I would say things like "It's important to diversify!", because I'd read it in a newspaper article when I was 17.

But that's fine.

After all, why should I know how to grow?

I was a new entrepreneur with no business background.

My guess is that you're a first-time entrepreneur, too.

Welcome to the club.

They didn't teach this stuff in school, so we're all learning from the school of hard knocks.

Diversifying Content

Anyway, one of the things that was always on my mind with StoryLearning was our reliance on organic traffic, as I mentioned earlier. For many of the early years of the business, we were completely reliant on Google. If Google released a new core algorithm update and our search rankings took a hit, we'd be in trouble.

In reality, this never happened.

Not once. Not enough for us to notice, anyway.

My belief is that it's because we've always focused on such quality long-form content. Quality always rises to the top.

Nevertheless, I knew that I needed to diversify traffic sources sooner or later, so that I wasn't reliant fully on one source. This was for my own peace of mind, the stability of the business and team, but also for any potential future buyers. I think my real forays into diversification began from this need.

Truth is, it took me a long time to begin to properly diversify content. And I think a lot of this came down to three things:

1. Knowing which media we should focus on
2. How to do it without me at the centre
3. The cost involved

There are a lot of unknowns here, and it was very different from how I built the business in the early days – me writing blog posts straight from the heart.

And so we fiddled around with a number of different content experiments:

- A new niche YouTube channel (2017)
- Expansion of our self-publishing operation (2018)
- A daily podcast (2019)
- Facebook ads (2015)

Looking back, I think this was mostly guesswork.

I was aware that any of this could work in principle, but didn't really have a thesis behind it.

- *What I knew* - How to make amazing content by myself (solopreneur or creator mentality)
- *What I needed to know* - How to build a content team that could work independently (entrepreneur mentality)

There's a world of difference when you think about it.

Things changed dramatically when I started to upgrade my thinking around finance. The more comfortable I became with proactively reinvesting into the business, and tracking this spend through better reporting, the more new options became available to me.

When YouTube really began maturing as a platform a few years back, I took the decision to learn and master the platform. I built an entire production team around the effort, put real cash behind it and decided to give it a window of two years to experiment with.

One of the lessons I had learned from previous experiments was that it's essential to give new media properties time to grow. There's a litany of channels now lying dead and buried that we killed too soon because we were too impatient to see traction.

“We can’t justify keeping this going unless we see an ROI.”

How wrong I was.

All we had to do was wait. Hurry up and be patient.

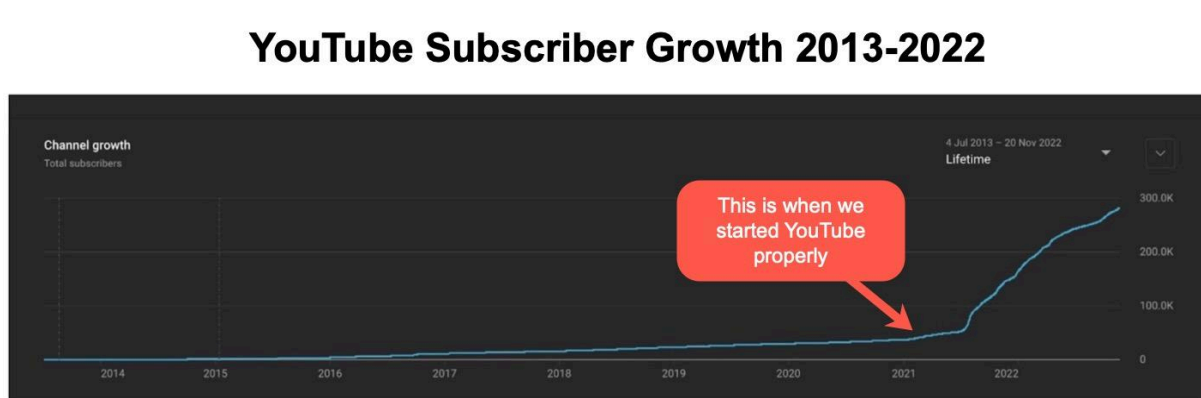
Easy to say with hindsight.

But having made that mistake a bunch of times, I was finally ready to commit to the new YouTube channel with time, money and resources.

Even I was amazed with what happened next.

We started to build 100,000s of subscribers, be inundated with sponsorship requests, and drive huge amounts of traffic and sales to the main website and business.

Here’s that graph that you saw earlier on in the case study:



The reason this worked is because

- a. We were on the right side of a fast-growing platform
- b. I fully-resourced the opportunity and went at it with determination

I suppose the only reason we were able to do this was because of our previous experiments where we cut things off too soon.

It’s the overnight success story...seven years in the making!

But they were lessons worth learning, because YouTube quickly became 30% of our entire traffic, and we reached breakeven on the cost of running the channel *from adsense revenue alone* within the first year.

This was a huge lesson for me because I saw what was possible when we combined proper resourcing with proper focus – i.e. people and money. Since then, we've continued this theme of investing into diversified content channels, and I'm sure over the coming years you will see many new content platforms from us.

As my mentor once told me, this way of working is essentially replicating the way I grew in the first place... building audience, and then offering products for sale.

The difference this time was that we were using *resources*, not my *time*.

And I'm really doing this with a 3-5 year time horizon, which is really important to understand because, as I'd learnt the hard way:

The fastest way to kill a new content platform is to be in a rush to see ROI.

It's one of the other huge benefits in the long-term thinking business model.

While everyone else is day trading with traffic and clicks, we are busy building a long-term asset that will only get stronger over time. My ultimate goal for the business is to have 4-5 independent traffic streams contributing more or less equally, such that one traffic source could be shut down completely by our Google overlords, and it would make a negligible difference to the business.

I think this is what a strong and stable online business really looks like, and it will be a good day when we get there.

We are not there yet, for sure, but we're getting closer every day, and I think the graph is rebalancing each time we look at it

Diversifying Revenue Streams

Next up is diversification of where the cash comes from.

I think diversifying revenue streams is far less important than diversifying traffic, for the simple reason that you are in control of your revenue-generating activities.

As long as you are getting good quality leads coming through, and your offering is a good one, there is no real reason that you would experience any big shocks, other than general changes in trends over time.

(I have many friends in B2B where 30-50% of their revenue comes from one big client. This is an accident looking for a place to happen.)

A good example is online courses, where the self-study model is changing into cohort-based courses. This is something we are seeing at the moment. But this is just a question of keeping on top of trends, responding to customer needs, and reinforcing the idea of having product owners, like we spoke about in chapter 7.

For StoryLearning, diversification of revenue streams was something that happened more organically than by design, to be honest.

It began when I learnt from Dan Kennedy about the concept of *unused capacity*.

This is the idea that we all have assets in our business which are underutilised, and can be put to work in one way or another.

For example, a spare seat in your office that you could rent out to a freelancer, or a bunch of filming gear you have sitting around that you could rent out on a day rate to production crews.

- I started to look all around our business for unused capacity
- I realised that we could offer sponsorships to our newly burgeoning YouTube channel, which could bring in \$1,000s a time
- I started to licence some of our older, unused products to third-party course sellers
- I found points along the customer journey where we had people's full attention and it was appropriate to make an offer - such as upon completion of a course

The list goes on.

However, we also developed a [certification programme](#), which is a variation on a High Ticket Offer, where we train new teachers to teach languages online. This came from spotting a kind of unused capacity within our business, which was *people who wanted to earn an income online by teaching*.

The certification was not just another opportunity to make money, though. Far from it, really. It was a substantial, long-term project in an area where we have deep expertise. In fact, we went into the certification expecting to not make any profit for the first two years.

However, from a diversification perspective, it allowed us to do something very important – maximise revenue from our customer base. Whereas a customer may ordinarily spend \$300-\$500 on a language course with us, they could now spend \$5000 and upwards to become certified.

This is an important layer of diversification, because even if the main course business ever began to lose revenue, we would make up for it easily with the certification programme. Given that they are quite different offers, it offers a degree of protection from random events in the business, marketplace or even in the wider economy. For example, in a recession, people tend to increase the amount they spend on training, in order to create more options for themselves.

In short, this offer complements the language business in every conceivable way.

Diversification of Vision

In the sub-seven-figure days, we were really just focused on growth and much of that came from doing *more of the same* until we hit scale.

But, as I became more aware of the limitations of our business model, and the various risks involved (including the risk of boredom, which can strike anyone unawares and even blow up your entire business), I wanted to set a vision for the company that would allow us to expand in different ways, which in turn would add a layer of stability to what we do.

Imagine if, in the future, we not only sold language courses, but also trained teachers, offered a live tutoring platform, and provided language services like translation, for example. This would add an even greater level of stability to the business, which would make it able to weather many different storms.

We are still very much in the throes of building out this vision right now, so watch this space to see how it goes. But it is a large part of our growth plan, and whatever the future of the company may hold, this growth will be a large part of the picture over the next 5-10 years.

One very interesting offshoot of building out this vision, incidentally, was when I presented it to the team.

We were all gathered at our annual team retreat in Turkey, spending a week in a beautiful villa looking over the sea. On the first day, I laid out some cards on a big table, and described to the team where I thought we could take StoryLearning over the long term:



Every single person told me later that it was the most inspirational part of the week, and made them feel part of something much bigger.

This was surprising for me to hear, but also very moving and energising.

It reinforced the idea that a team needs a vision, and can achieve great things when they are given one.

Diversification Through Investing

The final big element to diversifying for us has been investing.

I have committed \$100,000s to buying stakes in companies that are complementary to StoryLearning.

The main advantage of investing, rather than building, is speed.

If you have the available capital, you can add a new operation to your business literally overnight, rather than spending years creating it from scratch.

By investing in external companies, you also get the benefit of exponential growth, because you're piggy-backing on the growth of multiple companies, instead of just one.

For example, I own part of a language tutoring company, where you can find a teacher and take private lessons. It's highly-complementary to our main business, and one where we have an unfair advantage in helping them grow. Over time, we will be able to add value to both companies.

In another example, I own 50% of a company which works directly with creators to build their own education businesses. This is a way to take the knowledge that I've built up from 10 years of growing StoryLearning, and leverage that to have an impact

in businesses outside my own. (If you're a YouTuber with at least 1m subscribers, get in touch!)

One such company we've built from scratch is [Streetsmart Languages](#), and if you poke around you'll see many of the lessons from this case study in action.

So that's diversification.

Fun, right?

However...

And this is a *big* however...

Don't even think about doing any of this stuff until you're doing \$1 million in revenue.

I wouldn't want to tell you how to do things, and God knows I wouldn't even have paid attention to myself five years ago anyway.

But I feel that entrepreneurs do well to earn their stripes first, before considering a vision that is too grand.

I've come to think that business is a lot simpler than most of us make it out to be. Like Gary Halbert's famous hotdog stand metaphor, the basics of running a successful company are finding people with a need (the starving crowd leaving the stadium), and serving them with the best possible thing (the hotdog stand right outside the exit).

Although the premise is simple, the execution is not easy.

I think people get bored because they haven't quite figured out what to sell from the stand, or where exactly to put it. (They're selling fruit salads from halfway down the street instead.)

But instead of figuring this stuff out... they diversify instead. (They add a vegan burrito stand round the corner... maybe that will work?)

Even worse, they create a grand vision – a network of food stands outside every stadium in the country.

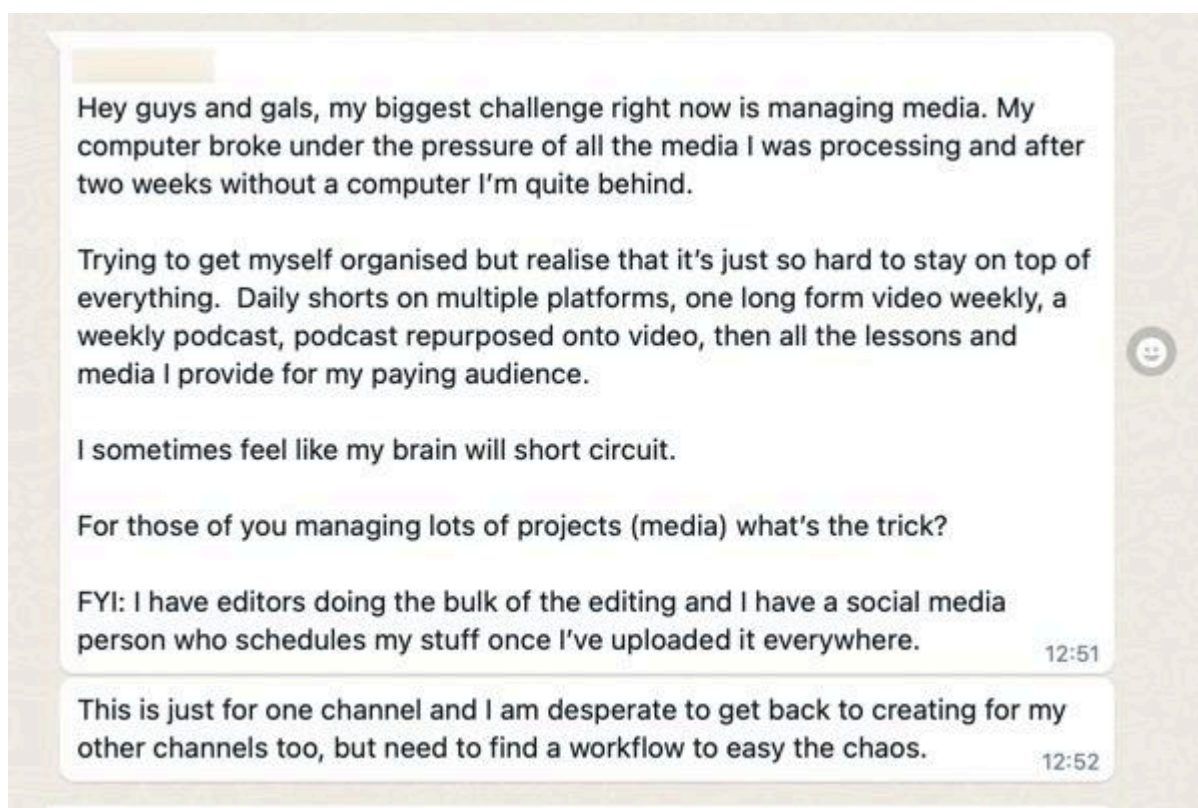
Whereas in reality, all they really ever needed to do was to learn to do the basics well – put one hotdog stand right outside the stadium exit.

I think a vision can be damaging until you have an established business, because it can get in the way of finding traction.

I think diversifying your products or revenue streams too early can stunt your growth, because you bloat your operations every which way till Sunday.

Similarly, diversifying your traffic sources too early is a big mistake, because it can slow your growth, rob you of time and cause you untold stress trying to hold it all together.

I'll give you just one example I came across just a few days ago:



The immediate cost here is overwhelm.

The hidden cost is worse – how many years will this entrepreneur hold themselves back by not creating the space to think, strategise and grow?

What about time with the family, or quality sleep? The ability to take proper holidays without stressing over yesterday's reel on IG.

And so, in whatever way this message lands, please take it the right way. It's a lesson I've learnt the hard way, and I see founders making the same mistakes everywhere I look.

How To Diversify

So you've heeded my various warnings, and you're ready to diversify.

How do you do it?

Remember, the point isn't to diversify for the sake of it. You want to diversify strategically.

And the big limiting factor in knowing what to do next is your own knowledge and experience. This is one of the reasons I always work with coaches and mentors – I don't want to ever let ignorance be the reason I make a poor decision, when the knowledge you need is out there ready for taking. (Or for *purchasing*, to be more precise!)

The higher the level of knowledge you seek, the more expensive it becomes. I've paid over \$100,000 for mentorship in the past. And it was worth every penny.

So, by far the smartest way to figure out how to diversify is to work with a mentor who's 5-10 years ahead of you in a similar field, and learn from them.

But short of having that mentor to advise you, here's what to do, based on all the trial and error I went through during those years when I didn't have a mentor either.

1. **Exploit marketplaces** – Big companies have already built large marketplaces with millions of existing customers with their credit cards already stored in the system:

- a. Amazon Kindle - 30m active Kindle readers in the US
- b. Udemy - 52 million learners
- c. Groupon - 24 million customers

If you can successfully participate in these marketplaces, you can get a lot of traction very quickly. I did this with my first kindle book experiments back in 2014, and then more recently with our YouTube channel. Point is - figure out where people are already active, and learn how to get involved.

2. **Allocate time to experiments** – You've probably heard the story that Google allows its staff 20% of their time to work on their own experiments, and that these experiments have resulted in products like Google Maps and Gmail. I

have no idea how true this is, but we recently did an exercise internally where we looked back at our most successful ideas over the years, and, sure enough, many of them came from experiments. We certainly don't have a big system or policy around experiments, but I plan on letting people have a lot more free reign with experiments moving forward

3. **Join masterminds, make friends** - Some of the best advice, ideas, and breakthroughs I've ever had have come from the proverbial conversations around the water cooler. Meaning, they've come from other people! One thing you don't have to do in your business is reinvent the wheel. Whatever it is you do, there are people who have been doing that thing successfully for a long time, and very little is new in business. While it's certainly the case that you can overdose on conferences and mastermind events at the expense of actually working on your business, I think we all need to be spending lots of time around other entrepreneurs, whether that be through friendship, masterminds, retreats or whatever you fancy. The idea is to increase the surface area onto which ideas can stick, and being around other people is the single best way to do this. I don't care how smart you are, you always have blind spots that can be filled by other people.
4. **Coaches, consultants & mentors** - Online courses can be great when you're new to business, because simple frameworks can get you started and will often work. However, bigger businesses need personalised advice from someone who actually has eyes on the inner workings of your business. Sometimes, they will see blindingly obvious things you never saw. Other times, they will give you creative solutions that come from experience. Fun fact, even the name StoryLearning didn't come from me. I was too close to the business to come up with such a straightforward name. The name was coined by a consultant friend I have worked with for years, and I will forever be grateful for that.

Summary

In this chapter, I explained how I think about diversification, in terms of content, revenue streams, investing and vision. I gave a few ways I have discovered over the years to find the ideas for these experiments, but also cautioned against doing this too early, as it can distract from the main goal of the business – to get traction.

10. Thoughts On Lifestyle

In this chapter I'm going to describe how I think about the balance between business, finances and lifestyle, and how I have structured StoryLearning to optimise for this. Read this chapter if you ever feel unsure about how hard you should be working, or what it's all for!

Time for a change of pace.

How hard should you actually be working? Are you weak if you take a day off? How about a week off? Should you keep the business as a cash flowing asset, or aim to grow it to sell?

These are all questions that I have wrestled with for years, and sought answers from a lot of people far smarter than me. So I'd like to think that putting my thoughts on this down on paper might be helpful to somebody.

At the end of the day, we all run our businesses in order to live an epic life, free from shackles, and full of abundance and happiness.

So why is it that all anyone talks about is growing your business? Surely we should spend just as much time talking about optimising our lifestyles.

That's what this chapter is about.

And I don't mean optimising your lifestyle in some hideous Tim Ferriss life-hack kind of way. I'm simply talking about living life in whatever damn way you want.

The reason I'm devoting a whole chapter to this is because I found it very difficult in the past to make sense of my personal goals, and the relationship of money to those goals.

Conference speakers and success gurus all said:

"Write down your 5, 10 and 20 year financial goals on a piece of paper! Then, develop your strategy to get there!"

Me?

Didn't have a clue.

I never cared that much about money, so long as I had plenty of it.

The idea of a 20 year financial goal to me is as abstract as that other horrendous question: *"Describe your perfect day!"*

What a load of nonsense.

Who the hell wants every day to be the same?

And whoever thought that defining some arbitrary amount of money, and then spending the next 20 years working towards that number, was ever a good way to live your life?

Who knows... maybe that's what all the smart kids do. But for me, it never made any sense.

So, does that mean I didn't care about the future and just enjoyed every day as it came?

Unfortunately not.

Because, while I didn't have any specific future goals, there was something that I wanted:

More.

A dangerous word.

It didn't really matter what the thing was... money, free time, traffic, subscribers, published books...

I had just got into the habit of never being satisfied.

Maybe it's because I'm naturally ambitious. Maybe it's because I never really had any money or success at anything, so I just got used to needing "more stuff" in general.

Whatever the cause, this was a dangerous cycle, because it meant that I could never really be satisfied with anything. Worse – because I didn't have a future number to aim for, there would never be an end to this curse of "more".

As a result of this, I spent quite a few years suffering from low-level anxiety in different forms.

And I know this is a common experience for entrepreneurs.

How do I know this?

Because it was other entrepreneurs who helped me solve it. (Along with a short but wonderful dose of therapy.)

It was Michael Singer who first opened my eyes to the notion that:

Attachment is the root of all suffering

It took me a while to understand this.

Attachment to what?

What I eventually began to realise was that attachment is a concept rooted in the future.

Future outcomes. Future results. Future events.

And the most important thing to understand about the future is that it is not the present.

It follows that happiness is rooted in the present.

Or to put it another way:

Being present is the secret to happiness

Whoa...

How's that for a bit of woo-woo nonsense for a Friday afternoon?

I'm going to stop this right here, for fear of losing half my readership, but I just want to say that the page you've just read is the single most important thing I've learnt about myself in the last 20 years, and I've become a much happier person since understanding this.

I know it's not relevant for everyone.

My Dutch business partner in CreatorEmpires.com would look at me, completely bemused, and say “*WTF are you talking about?*”

But, if this resonates with you even slightly, then you know what I’m talking about. Feel free to drop me a line if you’re suffering at all with this.

I tend to take the things I do seriously.

And understanding the nature of attachment and the future has really released me and allowed me to be fully present and enjoy life to the full...

Not to mention the ability to actually enjoy the fruits of the business I’ve spent years building!

After all, this is a chapter about lifestyle, right?

So...

To understand this a bit more, let’s talk about business goals.

Business Goals

I’m always in awe of people who seem to have complete conviction over what they want with their business.

Grow to sell. Take out every penny each year. Put the business in a trust for the employees. (Very trendy in the UK now, by the way.)

I even have a friend who refuses to take dividends from her company because she considers dividends immoral, instead paying full tax on a large salary. This is crazy to me, but I deeply admire her conviction.

There are so many different takes on business, and on money for that matter, and unfortunately for me... I don’t always know my own mind.

I guess I grew up without ever having the problem of knowing what to do with money. I started my career as a jazz musician, so you can imagine my relationship with money at that point...

I didn’t have any.

As a musician, I had already resolved myself to the fact that my life would be one of fun... all music all the time.

“You won’t make a lot of money if you have a career as a jazz musician,” my mum warned me when I was 16.

She wasn’t wrong.

Fast-forward 20 years and my life is unrecognisable.

Building a business, you inevitably sacrifice a lot of time and quality of life at the beginning, in order to get the thing off the ground.

Then eventually, you start making money.

So I ended up in the *exact opposite situation* to what I had before...

More money... less time.

And that’s where the problems started.

I didn’t like the fact I had less time. So I set about redesigning the business in such a way that I wasn’t needed, gradually eliminating myself from the business almost entirely.

That was good.

Now, I’m lucky enough to be in a situation where I have a lot of money... and a lot of time.

So, having been through this rollercoaster, what do I think a happy entrepreneurial life looks like exactly?

A Happy Entrepreneurial Life

Let me tell you about my life.

I live in a small village in the Southwest UK, which my friend [Idahosa Ness](#) affectionately describes as Hobbitshire.



I have 5 acres of land, stables with horses (although they're not actually mine... long story), a beautiful office with views over a rolling valley, gym in the garage, etc. You get the idea.

It's nice here.

I live 10 minutes from some of the best beaches in the country, and often go for a 1-2 hour walk along the coast in the morning. Sometimes, I'll take my laptop and work out of a beachside cafe.

I wake up at 6:15am every day and go for a one hour walk in the countryside around my house, before the day starts. I take my daughter to school every day, collect her in the afternoon, and take her to swimming and singing lessons during the week. We have dinner together as a family every evening, and at the weekends have dinner parties, go driving around the countryside, or just chill out.

I'm studying for my private pilot licence and go flying at least once a week. I see a personal trainer on Tuesdays and Fridays who thoroughly kicks my ass. I go to London once a month and stay for a few days, meeting friends, soaking up the atmosphere, and getting ripped off left, right and centre for flat whites that the baristas take as seriously as a heart attack.

We take three or four holidays a year, and I travel every few months for work too. This year, I've been to Portugal, France, Morocco and Argentina.

It's been a good year.

In amongst all this, I work.

I'm capable of working extremely hard, often for long hours. I draw a huge amount of energy from working, and I love building my business. I hardly ever work *in* the business itself. Whenever I do work, it's because I'm growing something new within the business.

This is the fundamental reason I am able to be free with my time.

Nothing that happens inside the business is dependent on me at any point, giving me flexibility to work whenever I want.

It's also very helpful that our entire business model is largely passive. Since we sell digital courses and books, there is very little that needs to happen in the way of fulfilment. Student communities, questions and answers, can be easily managed asynchronously by staff.

I calculate that I work about six full days a month inside the business.

But don't confuse this with shirking.

Thing is, I've noticed that the less I work, the more effective I am.

I spend quite a lot of time doing my own things, and might only work for a few hours a day.

But then when I work... I really work.

This case study, for example, I started writing at 8:30am this morning, and I'm still going at 3:30pm. There's nothing like writing. One thing I've learnt about myself is that I need both work and leisure in equal measure. Too much of either, and I'm simply not happy.

Without a doubt, I have built StoryLearning over the years to be a business that allows me to live my life exactly how I want. Although we go through periods of intense work and building, such as when we were building the new [certification programme](#).

However, everything is done with the principle that, before long, it will be systematised and delegated, owned and managed by others.

People often get confused by this when they come to my [website](#) and see my face plastered everywhere. They assume that I must be extremely busy “running the business”, but in reality my position has become much more of the celebrity endorser than the person who actually runs the business.

This is something to think very carefully about if you are still knees-deep in operations yourself, working long hours and not seeing your family enough.

Based on all this, here are a few things that I have learnt about myself personally:

1. I have no interest in hustling my whole life to build a \$1 billion company
2. I know with 99% certainty that making any more money than I have now will make zero impact on my happiness
3. I treasure having complete time freedom – take the day off, go on holiday, or work all day
4. I believe that the currency of life is experiences, and when we are in our old age, we will judge our life based on experiences we’ve had (not money in the bank)

I've come to understand these things precisely because I have spent time in my life doing the exact opposite:

- I have gone through periods of extreme hustle to the point that I burnt out and couldn't get off the sofa for weeks on end
- I have made millions of dollars and felt less happy than I did before making them
- I have seen my calendar booked back-to-back for days on end
- I have spent years prioritising business over life experiences
- I have got involved in things I shouldn't have, said yes to far too many things, and become stressed and anxious as a result

Can you relate to any of these things? Maybe you can, maybe you can't.

But what I know for sure is that the things I just described are so horrible, so energy-sucking, so “anti-living”... and I dislike them so much that the four principles mentioned above have become the closest thing I have to a rulebook for my life.

I think, subconsciously, this is why I have built StoryLearning the way I have, and probably why the principles I've talked about in this case study have become the principles they are.

Because, somehow, I have known deep down that they matter to me. (I just hadn't been able to articulate it yet.)

And for this reason, I have actively shunned lots of so-called "business growth opportunities" that don't fit with these principles.

From this has emerged another principle that I often bring up in team meetings when we're considering a new idea:

How do we minimise complexity and maximise simplicity?

So much of the magic of the StoryLearning business model is that it is very simple.

It's lean. It's passive. It's efficient.

I have absolutely no interest in adding anything whatsoever that will add complexity to the business, which in turn needs managing and worrying about.

And yes, and that holds true even if it means making less money.

Things go well when things are simple.

People are happy when things are simple.

Of course, one of the benefits of making a lot of money in the first place is that you have the luxury of saying no.

So build a business that's simple.

Build a business that you like.

Build a business that works for you.

I'd go so far as to say that you have an obligation to yourself, your family and your friends to build a business based on what works best for you.

They'll thank you for it.

You'll live a happier, more fulfilling life.

And if you can do all this...

Why would you ever sell?

Summary

In this chapter, I've given you a personal take on the relationship between business and lifestyle. I've talked about the danger of attachment to outcomes, the importance of being rooted in the present, and the value of designing a business based on what *you* want.

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